

Chapter 1

Addiss & Lombardo

Chapter 1

Raymond B. Blakney

Chapter 1

David Bullen

Chapter 1

David Hong Cheng

Chapter 1

Ellen Marie Chen

Tao called Tao is not
Tao. Names can
name no lasting
name.

Nameless: the origin
of heaven and earth.
Naming: the mother
of ten thousand
things.

Empty of desire,
perceive mystery.

There are ways but
the Way is
uncharted;

There are names but
not nature in words:

Nameless indeed is
the source of creation

But things have a
mother and she has a
name.

The secret waits for
the insight

Of eyes

Words cannot
describe the Tao, and
The Tao cannot be
named. That which is
eternal is
unnameable. Naming
is the basis of things.
Free from desire you
are a mystery.

Tao that can be
described is not the
universal and eternal
Tao;

Name that can be
named is not the
universal and eternal
name.

The beginning of
Heaven and Earth is
nameless;

The mother of
everything is naming.

Thus:

Tao that can be spoken of,

Is not the Everlasting
(ch'ang) Tao.

Name that can be named,

Is not the Everlasting
(ch'ang) name.

Nameless (wu-ming), the
origin (shih) of heaven
and earth;

Named (yu-ming), the
mother (mu) of ten
thousand things.

Alternate,

Non-being (wu), to name
(ming) the origin (shih) of
heaven and earth;

Being (yu), to name
(ming) the mother of ten
thousand things.

Therefore, always
(ch'ang) without desire
(wu-yü),

In order to observe

(kuan) the hidden mystery

—

Filled with desire,
perceive
manifestations.

These have the same
source, but different
names.

Call them both deep -
Deep and again deep:
the gateway to all
mystery.

unclouded by
longing;

Those who are bound
by desire

See only the outward
container.

These two come
paired but distinct

By their names.

Of all things
profound,

Say that their pairing
is deepest,

The gate to the root
of the world.

Caught in desire you
are known. The
mystery and the
known are not
separate. It is naming
which separates us.
Only through
paradox can you
understand.

Be always objective,
one discover the
wonders;

Be always subjective,
one only sees the
manifestations.

Both emerge from
the same source, but
with different names.

Both are mysterious.

The mystery hidden
inside of mysteries

Is the door to all
wonders.

(miao);

Always (ch'ang) with
desire (yu-yü),

In order to observe the
manifestations (chiao).

Alternate,

Therefore, by the
Everlasting (ch'ang)
Non-Being (wu),

We desire (yü) to observe
(kuan) its hidden mystery
(miao);

By the Everlasting
(ch'ang) Being (yu),

We desire (yü) to observe
the manifestations (chiao).

These two issue from the
same origin,

Though named
differently.

Both are called the dark
(hsüan).

Dark and even darker,

Chapter 2

Addiss & Lombardo

Chapter 2

Raymond B. Blakney

Chapter 2

David Bullen

Chapter 2

David Hong Cheng

Chapter 2

Ellen Marie Chen

Recognize beauty
and ugliness is born.

Recognize good and
evil is born.

Is and Isn't produce
each other. Hard
depends on easy,
Long is tested by
short,

High is determined
by low, Sound is
harmonized by voice,
After is followed

Since the world points
up beauty as such,

There is ugliness too.

If goodness is taken as
goodness,

Wickedness enters as
well.

For is and is-not come
together;

Hard and easy are
complementary;

Long and short are
relative;

High and low are
comparative;

Pitch and sound make
harmony;

Before and after are a
sequence.

Indeed the Wise Man's

Beauty doesn't exist;
Ugliness doesn't
exist: except through
the other. Good
doesn't exist; bad
doesn't exist: except
through the other.
Long doesn't exist;
short doesn't exist:
except through the
other. High doesn't
exist; low doesn't
exist: except through
the other. Before
doesn't exist; after
doesn't exist: except
through the other.
Inside doesn't exist;
outside doesn't exist:
except through the
other.

When the world
knows what beauty
is, then there is
ugliness;

When the world
knows what good is,
then there is evil.

Thus:

Being and Non-being
produce each other,

Difficult and easy
complement each
other,

Long and short
calibrate each other,

High and low
contrast each other,

Music and noise
harmonize each
other, and

Front

When all under
heaven know beauty
(mei) as beauty,

There is then ugliness
(o);

When all know the
good (shan) good,

There is then the not
good (pu shan).

Therefore being and
non-being give rise to
each other,

The difficult and easy
complement each
other,

The long and short
shape each other,

The high and low lean
on each other,

by before.

Therefore the sage is
devoted to non
action, Moves
without teaching,

Creates ten thousand
things without
instruction, Lives but
does not own, Acts
but does not
presume,

Accomplishes
without taking credit.
When no credit is
taken,
Accomplishment
endures.

office

Is to work by being
still;

He teaches not by
speech

But by
accomplishment;

He does for everything,

Neglecting none;

Their life he gives to
all,

Possessing none;

And what he brings to
pass

Depends on no one
else.

As he succeeds,

He takes no credit

And just because he
does not take it,

Profit doesn't exist;
loss doesn't exist:
except through the
other. Therefore the
master acts without
setting a goal, and
teaches that there is
no teaching. Freedom
from duality resides
with him. Everything
is his, but he has
nothing. Every act is
his, but he expects
nothing. This is his
accomplishment,
which can never be
destroyed.

and back accompany
each other.

Therefore the sage
chooses to:

Manage affairs by
taking no action;

Teach without
words;

Allow all things to
develop, but no to
start;

Produce, but not to
possess;

Care for, but not to
master;

Complete work, but
not to claim credit,

By not claiming
credit, his credit will
not be lost.

The front and rear
follow upon each
other.

Therefore the sage
manages affairs
without action,

Carries out (hsing)
teaching without
speech (yen).

Ten thousand things
arise and he does not
initiate them,

They come to be and
he claims no
possession (yu) of
them,

He works (wei)
without holding on,

Accomplishes
(ch'eng) without
claiming merit.

Because he does not
claim merit,

Chapter 3

Addiss & Lombardo

Chapter 3

Raymond B. Blakney

Chapter 3

David Bullen

Chapter 3

David Hong Cheng

Chapter 3

Ellen Marie Chen

Don't glorify heroes,
And people will not contend.

Don't treasure rare objects, And no one will steal.

Don't display what people desire, And their hearts will not be disturbed.

Therefore, the Sage rules By emptying

If those who are excellent find no preferment,

The people will cease to contend for promotion.

If goods that are hard to obtain are not favored,

The people will cease to turn robbers or bandits.

If things much desired are kept under cover,

Disturbance will cease in the minds of the

A great man who doesn't display his talent has no rivals.
A wealthy man who doesn't flaunt his wealth sees no thieves. The master teaches the value of humility and the futility of ambition.

Do not ennoble achievers, so the people will not become contentious;

Do not value rare commodities, so the people will not be tempted to steal;

Do not display temptations, so the people's minds will not be disturbed.

Therefore, a wise ruler would:

Humble

Do not honor (shang) the worthy (hsien),

So that the people will not contend (cheng) with one another.

Do not value (kuei) hard-to-get goods,

So that the people will not turn robbers.

Do not show objects of desire (k'o yü),

So that the people's minds (hsin) are not disturbed.

Therefore, when

hearts and filling bellies, By weakening ambitions and strengthening bones; Leads people Away from knowing and wanting;

Deters those who know too much From going too far:

Practices non-action And the natural order is not disrupted.

people.

The Wise Man's policy, accordingly,

Will be to empty people's hearts and minds,

To fill their bellies, weaken their ambition,

Give them sturdy frames and always so,

To keep them uninformed, without desire,

And knowing ones not venturing to act.

Be still while you work

And keep full control Over all.

He empties their minds of all they know and helps them extinguish desires. Those who think they know cannot understand him. Don't work at anything, and everything will work.

the people's minds;

Fill their stomachs;

Weaken their ambitions, and

Strengthen their bodies.

Always keep the people ignorant and devoid of desire,

Even the cunning ones dare not agitate.

Achieve the ideal of taking no action,

Then there will be no misgoverned state.

the sage rules:

He empties the minds (hsin) of his people,

Fills their bellies,

Weakens their wills (chih),

And strengthens their bones.

Always he keeps his people in no-knowledge (wu-chih) and no-desire (wu-yü),

Such that he who knows dares not act.

Act by no-action (wu-wei),

Then, nothing is not in order.

Chapter 4

Addiss & Lombardo

Chapter 4

Raymond B. Blakney

Chapter 4

David Bullen

Chapter 4

David Hong Cheng

Chapter 4

Ellen Marie Chen

Tao is empty- its use
never exhausted.

Bottomless - the
origin of all things.

It blunts sharp edges,
Unties knots, Softens
glare,

The Way is a void,
Used but never filled:

An abyss it is,
Like an ancestor
From which all
things come.

It blunts sharpness,
Resolves tangles;
It tempers

The Tao is always
used, but never
empties. It is eternal
and infinite but is
nothing.

Tao is empty, yet
forever
inexhaustible.

It is so far-reaching,
the source for
everything.

Blunting
sharpnesses,
resolving conflicts,
softening lights.

It thus harmonizes
the dusty

Tao is a whirling
emptiness (ch'ung),
Yet (erh) in use
(yung) is
inexhaustible (ying).
Fathomless (yuan),
It seems to be the
ancestor (tsung) of
ten thousand beings.
It blunts the sharp,
Unties the

Becomes one with
the dusty world.

Deeply subsistent -
I don't know whose
child it is. It is older
than the Ancestor.

light,
Subdues turmoil.
A deep pool it is,
Never to run dry!
Whose offspring it
may be
I do not know:
It is like a preface to
God.

You can't find it even
though it is always
here. Since it creates
everything how can
we know who
created it.

world.

So deep and
profound,
It has forever existed.

I do not now whose
child it is,
It has existed before
the notion of god.

entangled,
Harmonizes the
bright,
Mixes the dust.
Dark (chan),
It seems perhaps to
exist (ts'un).
I do not know whose
child it is,
It is an image
(hsiang) of what
precedes God (Ti).

Chapter 5

Addiss & Lombardo

Chapter 5

Raymond B. Blakney

Chapter 5

David Bullen

Chapter 5

David Hong Cheng

Chapter 5

Ellen Marie Chen

Heaven and Earth are not kind: The ten thousand things are straw dogs to them.

The Sage is not kind: People are straw dogs to him.

Is then the world unkind?

And does it treat all things

Like straw dogs used in magic rites?

The Wise Man too, is he unkind?

And does he treat the folk

Like straw dogs made

The Tao is impartial; good and evil both reside herein. The master is impartial, and regards all as equal.

Heaven and earth are inhumane,

They treat all things like straw dogs;

The rule is inhumane,

He treats his people like straw dogs.

Between the heaven and earth, is it

Heaven and earth are not humane (jen),

They treat the ten thousand beings as straw dogs (ch'u kou).

The sage is not humane (jen),

He treats the hundred families as straw dogs (ch'u kou).

Between heaven and earth,

Yet Heaven and Earth And all the space between Are like a bellows: Empty but inexhaustible, Always producing more.

Longwinded speech is exhausting. Better to stay centered.

to throw away?

Between the earth and sky

The space is like a bellows,

Empty but unspent.

When moved its gift is copious.

Much talk means much exhaustion;

Better far it is to keep your thoughts!

The Tao contains nothing but is able to create anything. As it is used, it produces. If you talk of it your understanding will grow dim. Remain impartial.

like a bellows?

It is empty yet inexhaustible; and

More agitations produce even more disturbances.

Much arguments are destined to end,

It is better to remain with the central core.

How like a bellows (t'o yo) it is!

Empty and yet inexhaustible,

Moving and yet it pours out ever more.

By many words one's reckoning (shu) is exhausted.

It is better to abide by the center (shou chung).

Chapter 6

Addiss & Lombardo

Chapter 6

Raymond B. Blakney

Chapter 6

David Bullen

Chapter 6

David Hong Cheng

Chapter 6

Ellen Marie Chen

The Valley Spirit
never dies. It is
called the Mysterious
Female.

The entrance top the

The valley spirit is
not dead:

They say it is the
mystic female.

Her gateway is,

The Tao is like a
valley, receptive.
Your true essence is
the Tao, mysterious.
Because it never dies
it is mysterious.

The valley spirit
never dies,

It is the mysterious
female.

The gate of the
mysterious female,

Is

The Valley Spirit (ku
shen) is deathless,

It is called the Dark
Mare (hsüan p'in).

The door of the Dark
Mare,

Is

Mysterious Female Is
called the root of
Heaven and Earth.

Endless flow of
inexhaustible energy.

they further say,

The base of heaven
and earth.

Constantly, and so
forever,

Use her without
labor.

As it receives all we
say it is feminine.
From it arise all
dreams. It continues
without end and
death cannot stop it.

the root of Heaven
and Earth.

It exists forever in
continuum,

And using it, it is
inexhaustible.

called the root of
heaven and earth.

Continuous (mien
mien), it seems to
exist (ts'un),

Yet in use (yung) it is
inexhaustible.

Chapter 7

Addiss & Lombardo

Chapter 7

Raymond B. Blakney

Chapter 7

David Bullen

Chapter 7

David Hong Cheng

Chapter 7

Ellen Marie Chen

Heaven is long, Earth enduring.

Long and enduring
Because they do not exist for themselves.

Therefore the Sage

The sky is everlasting

And the earth is very old.

Why so? Because the world

Exists not for itself;

It can and will live on.

The Wise Man

As the Tao can never die, we call it eternal. Receiving all, we call it infinite. The birthless is eternal.

Heaven is permanent and Earth everlasting.

The reason Heaven and Earth are permanent and everlasting is that

They do not exist for themselves.

Therefore they last

Heaven and earth are long lasting (chiu).

The reason why heaven and earth are long lasting:

Because they do not live for self (pu tzu sheng).

Therefore they last long.

Thus the sage puts his body (shen)

Steps back, but is always in front, Stays outside, but is always within.

No self-interest?

Self is fulfilled?

chooses to be last

And so becomes the first of all;

Denying self, he too is saved.

For does he not fulfillment find

In being an unselfish man?

The desireless is infinite. Seeing this, a master seeks nothing so he has everything. He doesn't nourish the ego, so his nourishment is total.

forever.

Thus the sage:

Gets ahead by staying behind;

Survives by being selfless.

Is it not his being selfless that enables him to fulfill his wishes?

behind,

Yet his body is in front.

He regards his body as external,

Yet his body remains in existence (ts'un).

Is it not because he is selfless (wu szu),

That he can fulfill himself (ch'eng ch'i szu).

Chapter 8

Addiss & Lombardo

Chapter 8

Raymond B. Blakney

Chapter 8

David Bullen

Chapter 8

David Hong Cheng

Chapter 8

Ellen Marie Chen

Best to be like water,
Which benefits the
ten thousand things
And does not
contend. It pools
where humans
disdain to dwell,
Close to the Tao.
Live in a good place.

The highest
goodness, water-like,
Does good to
everything and goes
Unmurmuring to
places men despise;
But so, is close in
nature to the Way.
If the good of the
house is from land,
Or the good of the
mind is depth,
Or love is

To be truly good, be
like water which
benefits all without
knowing. Men who
aspire to ascend
benefit no being. But
all are benefited by
the natural descent of
water. This is like the
Tao. So seek a
dwelling for shelter.
Think when the need
arises.

The ultimate good is
like water.
Water benefits all
things without
competing with
them.
It stays at places
where all people
disdain,
Therefore it is close
to Tao.
A habitat is good
because of its
location;
A mind is good
because of its
profundity;
A friend is good

A person with
superior goodness
(shan) is like water,
Water is good in
benefiting (li) all
beings,
Without contending
(cheng) with any.
Situated in places
shunned (o) by many
others,
Thereby it is near
(chi) Tao.
(Such a person's)
dwelling is the good
earth,
(His/her) mind (hsin)
is the good deep

Keep your mind
deep. Treat others
well. Stand by your
word.
Make fair rules. Do
the right thing. Work
when it's time.
Only do not contend,
And you will not go
wrong.

the virtue of
friendship,
Or honesty blesses
one's talk,
Or in government,
goodness is order,
Or in business, skill
is admired,
Or the worth of an
act lies in timing,
Then peace is the
goal of the Way
By which no one
ever goes astray.

When you deal with
others, do so with
compassion. When
you speak to others,
don't lie. Work at a
profession for
self-refinement as
well as livelihood.
Lead your family by
simply following
them. When you
follow the natural
path no mistake can
be made.

because of his
kindness;
A statement is good
because of its
credibility;
A government is
good because of its
excellent
management;
A worker is good
because of his
productivity; and
A move is good
because of its
timeliness.
Only by being not
contentious,
Will there be no ill
will.

water (yuan),
(His/her) associates
are good kind people
(jen),
(His/her) speech
shows good trust
(hsin),
(His/her) governing
is the good order,
(His/her) projects
(shih) are carried out
by good talents
(neng),
(His/her) activities
(tung) are good in
timing.
Because he does not
contend (pu cheng)
with any,
He commits no
wrong.

Chapter 9

Addiss & Lombardo

Chapter 9

Raymond B. Blakney

Chapter 9

David Bullen

Chapter 9

David Hong Cheng

Chapter 9

Ellen Marie Chen

Hold and fill it - No
as good as stopping
in time.

Measure and pound it
- It will not long
survive.

To take all you want
Is never as good

As to stop when you
should.

Scheme and be sharp
And you'll not keep it
long.

One can never guard
His

Acting naturally, also
know when to stop
naturally. Balance is
lost if you would
continue.

Holding a cup to fill
it to brim,

It is better to stop in
time.

Making a sword
extremely sharp,

It is hard to keep its
sharpness for long.

Filling up a hall with
gold

To hold and fill (a
vessel) to the full
(ying),

It had better not be
done.

To temper and
sharpen a sword,

Its edge could not be
kept (pao) long.

To fill the hall with
gold and

When gold and jade
fill the hall, They
cannot be guarded.

Riches and pride
Bequeath error.

Withdrawing when
work is done:
Heaven's Tao.

home when it's full
Of jade and fine
gold:

Wealth, power and
pride

Bequeath their own
doom.

When fame and
success

Come to you, then
retire.

This is the ordained
Way.

Base your
achievement not on
results, but on
whether you
followed the act.
When the act is
complete, it is gone.
This is serene.

and jade;

It cannot be securely
guarded.

He who becomes
arrogant with wealth
and power,

Sows the seeds of his
own misfortune.

Retire once the work
is successfully
completed.

This is the way of
heaven.

jade,

There is no way to
guard (shou) them.

To be rich, exalted,
and proud,

This is to invite
blame (chiu) upon
oneself.

When work is done
(sui), the person
(sheng) retires,

Such is the Tao of
heaven.

Can you balance
your life force And
embrace the One
Without separation?

Can you control your
breath Gently Like a
baby?

Can you clarify Your
dark vision Without
blemish?

Can you love people
And govern the
country Without
knowledge?

Can you open

Can you govern your
animal soul, hold to
the One and
never depart from it?

Can you throttle your
breath, down to the
softness of
breath in a child?

Can you purify your
mystic vision and
wash it until it is
spotless?

Can you love all your
people, rule over the
land without
being

To keep the mind
balanced use the
body. Breathe like an
infant. Then cleanse
the mind by letting
go of ideas. Love
people without
interfering. Allow
events to take their
natural course.

Command your body
and soul to embrace
the One,

Can there be no
separation?

Concentrate your
vital energy to
achieve complete
softness,

Can you be like an
infant?

Cleanse your
thoughts and purify
your insight,

Can you be flawless?

In loving your people
and governing your
state,

Can you be without
preconception?

In bringing your
spiritual (ying) and
bodily (p'o) souls to
embrace the One,

Can (neng) you never
depart (li) from it?

In concentrating your
breath to attain
softness,

Can you be like an
infant (ying erh)?

In cleansing your
mirror (lan) of the
dark (hsüan),

Can you make it
spotless?

In opening and
closing heaven's gate
(t'ien men),

Can you be the
female (tz'u)?

and close The gate of
heaven Without
clinging to earth?

Can you brighten
The four directions
Without action?

Give birth and
cultivate. Give birth
and do not possess.
Act without
dependence. Excel
but do not rule. This
is called the dark Te.

known?

Can you be like a
female, and passively
open and shut
heaven's gates?

Can you keep clear in
your mind the four
quarters of earth
and not interfere?

Quicken them, feed
them;

Quicken but do not
possess them.

Act and be
independent;

Be the chief but
never the lord:

This describes the
mystic virtue.

Detached from
comings and goings
the mind is clear.
Don't bullshit
yourself! By
balancing it you
nurture it, but it is not
yours. Acting
through it, but
expecting no results.
Perfection comes of
its own accord.

of Heaven,

Can you behave like
a female?

In comprehending
and penetrating the
truth,

Can you be mindful
of taking no action
against Tao?

In producing and in
nurturing lives, you
are:

To produce, but not
to possess;

To care for, but not
to control;

To lead, but not to
subjugate.

This is known as the
profound virtue.

In being enlightened
(ming) and
comprehending all,

Can you do it without
knowledge?

In loving the people
and governing the
state,

Can you practice
non-action?

To give birth, to
nurture,

To give birth yet not
to claim possession
(yu),

To act (wei) yet not
to hold on to,

To grow (chang) yet
not to lord over
(tsai),

Chapter 11

Addiss & Lombardo

Chapter 11

Raymond B. Blakney

Chapter 11

David Bullen

Chapter 11

David Hong Cheng

Chapter 11

Ellen Marie Chen

Thirty spokes join one hub. The wheel's use comes from emptiness.

Clay is fired to make a pot. The pot's use comes from emptiness.

Thirty spokes will converge

In the hub of a wheel;

But the use of the cart

Will depend on the part

Of the hub that is void.

With a wall all around A clay bowl is molded;

But the use of the bowl

Will depend on the part

Without the hole in the tap, the water cannot flow. A cup has form for the emptiness inside.

Thirty spokes are joined around the wheel's hub,

Its non-being makes the carriage useful.

Clay is molded to make a pot,

Its non-being provides

Thirty spokes share one hub to make a wheel.

Through its non-being (wu),

There is (yu) the use (yung) of the carriage.

Mold clay into a vessel (ch'i).

Through its non-being (wu),

There is (yu) the use (yung) of the vessel.

Cut out doors

Windows and doors are cut to make a room. The room's use comes from emptiness.

Therefore, Having leads to profit, Not having leads to use.

Of the bowl that is void.

Cut out windows and doors

In the house as you build;

But the use of the house

Will depend on the space

In the walls that is void.

So advantage is had

From whatever is there;

But usefulness rises

From whatever is not.

Houses have four walls and a roof, but the space inside is where we live. Things seem to exist, but arise from non-existence.

the utility.

Doors and windows are cut to make a room,

Their utility is furnished by non-being.

Therefore,

Being only facilitates, non-being provides utility.

and windows to make a house.

Through its non-being (wu),

There is (yu) the use (yung) of the house.

Therefore in the being (yu-chih) of a thing,

There lies the benefit (li).

In the non-being (wu-chih) of a thing,

There lies its use (yun).

Chapter 12

Addiss & Lombardo

Chapter 12

Raymond B. Blakney

Chapter 12

David Bullen

Chapter 12

David Hong Cheng

Chapter 12

Ellen Marie Chen

Five colors darken
the eyes. Five tones
darken the ears. Five
tastes jade the palate.
Hunting and racing
madden the heart.

The five colors
darken the eye;
The five sounds will
deaden the ear;
The five flavors
weary the taste;
Chasing the beasts of
the field
Will drive a man
mad.
The goods that are

If you look at bright
light, you go blind. If
you listen to loud
noise, you go deaf.

The five colours may
blind one's eyes;
The five tones may
deafen one's ears;
The five flavours
may dull one's taste;
Racing and hunting
may madden one's

The five colors blind
a person's eyes;
The five musical
notes deafen a
person's ears;
The five flavors ruin
a person's taste buds.
Horse-racing,
hunting and chasing,
Drive a

Exotic goods ensnarl
human lives.
Therefore the Sage
Takes care of the
belly, not the eye,
Chooses one, rejects
the other.

hard to procure
Are hobbles that
slow walking feet.
So the Wise Man will
do What his belly
dictates
And never the sight
of his eyes.
Thus he will choose
this but not that.

Tasting many
flavours reduces the
tongue's sensitivity.
Many thoughts
confuse the mind.
Many desires break
your heart. Don't
crave anything.
Simply fulfil your
needs.

mind;
Rare commodities
may prompt people's
illicit activities.
Therefore,
The sage emphasizes
the essentials of life,
not the superficial
temptations.\So he
accepts this and
rejects the other.

person's mind (hsin)
to madness.
Hard-to-get goods,
Hinder a person's
actions.
Therefore the sage is
for the belly, not for
the eyes.
Therefore he leaves
this and chooses that.

Favour and disgrace are like fear. Honour and distress are like the self.

What does this mean? Favour debases us. Afraid when we get it, Afraid when we lose it.

The self embodies distress.

"Favor, like disgrace Brings trouble with it; High rank, like self, Involves acute distress."

What does that mean, to say

That "favor, like disgrace Brings trouble with it"?

When favor is bestowed

On one of low degree, Trouble will come with it.

The loss of favor too Means trouble for that man.

This, then, is what is meant

By "favor, like disgrace

A man hopes to be successful and fears failure. Why? Because he is someone important. Neither hope nor fear can sway a master though. Why? Because a master knows he is no one important.

Exceptional favour or disgrace causes anxieties.

Treat calamities as treats to your body.

What is meant by "exceptional favour or disgrace causes anxieties"?

Exceptional favour is granted to someone of low status:

Whoever receives it is anxious about what is expected of him;

Whoever loses it is anxious about the accompanying disgrace.

This explains "exceptional favour or disgrace cause anxieties".

What is

Accept honors and disgraces as surprises, Treasure great misfortunes as the body.

Why say: "Accept honors and disgraces as surprises"?

Honors elevate (shang), Disgraces depress (hsia).

One receives them surprised, Loses them surprised.

Thus: "Accept honors and disgraces as surprises."

Why say: "Treasure great misfortunes as the body"?

I have

No self, No distress.

Respect the world as your self: The world can be your lodging. Love the world as your self: The world can be your trust.

What does it mean, to say

That "rank, like self, Involves acute distress"?

I suffer most because Of me and selfishness.

If I were selfless, then What suffering would I bear?

In governing the world, Let rule entrusted be To him who treats his rank

As if it were his soul; World sovereignty can be Committed to that man

Who loves all people As he loves himself.

Free from ideas of self-importance even life and death matter not. Success and failure lose all meaning. Here, how can hope and fear touch you? Seeing all things as equal you love all things as yourself.

meant by "treat calamities as threats to your body"?

The reason I encounter calamities is that I have e a body.

If I no longer have a body, what calamity do I have?

Therefore,

He who values the world as his self merits the confidence of the world;

He who loves the world as his self deserves the trust of the world.

great misfortunes, Because I have a body.

If I don't have a body, What misfortunes do I have?

Therefore treasure the body as the world, As if the body can be entrusted to the world.

Love the body as the world, As if the body can be entrusted to the world.

Seeing but not seeing, we call it dim. Listening but not hearing, we call it faint. Groping but not touching, we call it subtle.

These three cannot be fully grasped. Therefore they become one.

Rising, it is not bright; setting it is not dark.

They call it elusive, and say

That one looks

But it never appears.

They say that indeed it is rare,

Since one listens,

But never a sound.

Subtle, they call it, and say

That one grasps it

But never gets hold.

These three complaints amount

To only one, which is

Beyond all resolution.

At rising, it does not illumine;

At setting, no darkness ensues;

It stretches far back

The Tao cannot be seen, so don't look for it. You can't hear it, so don't listen for it. It is no-thing, so don't try to touch it. Timeless and dimensionless, it cannot be named.

Looking at without seeing it, it is invisible;

Listening to without hearing it, it is inaudible;

Holding onto without finding it, it is intangible;

These three need no further inquiry, they are thus merged into the One:

It is not bright above, nor dark below,

Boundless beyond description, and reverting back to nothingness.

What is looked at but not (pu) seen,

Is named the extremely dim (yi).

What is listened to but not heard,

Is named the extremely faint (hsi).

What is grabbed but not caught,

Is named the extremely small (wei).

These three cannot be comprehended,

Thus they blend into one.

As to the one, its coming up is not light,

Its going down is not darkness.

Unceasing, unnameable,

Again it reverts to nothing.

It moves all things back to where there is nothing

Meeting it there is no front, following it there is no back.

Live in the ancient Tao, Master the existing present, Understand the source of all things. This is called the record of Tao.

To that nameless estate Which existed before the creation.

Describe it as form yet unformed;

As shape that is still without shape;

Or say it is vagueness confused:

One meets it and it has no front;

One follows and there is no rear.

If you hold ever fast

To that most ancient Way,

You may govern today.

Call truly that knowledge

Of primal beginnings

The clue to the Way.

But all things are contained in it. Subtle beyond understanding. It is a beginningless and endless present. Not trying to find it, you can be it. Look, here you are!

It is a shape without form, an image without substance, and

A blurred ambiguity.

Facing it, one sees no head, and following it, one sees no back.

Holding fast the Tao of old,

For the understanding of current discoveries,

One may learn the beginning of Creation.

This is called the principle of Tao.

called the formless form, The image (hsiang) of nothing.

Therefore it is said to be illusive and evasive (hu-huang).

Come toward it one does not see its head,

Follow behind it one does not see its rear.

Holding on to the Tao of old (ku chih tao),

So as to steer in the world of now (chin chih yu).

To be able to know the beginning of old,

It is to know the thread of Tao.

Chapter 15

Addiss & Lombardo

The ancients who followed Tao: Dark, wondrous, profound, penetrating. Deep beyond knowing.

Because they cannot be known, They can only be described. Cautious, like crossing a winter stream. Hesitant, like respecting one's neighbours. Polite, like a guest.

Yielding, Like ice about to melt; Blank, like uncarved wood.

Chapter 15

Raymond B. Blakney

The excellent masters of old,

Subtle, mysterious, mystic, acute,

Were much too profound for their times.

Since they were not then understood,

It is better to tell how they looked.

Like men crossing streams in the winter,

How cautious!

As if all around there were danger,

How watchful!

As if they were guests on every occasion,

How dignified!

Like ice just beginning to

Chapter 15

David Bullen

All past masters of the Tao had deep penetration of the subtle. This subtlety cannot be understood. Therefore the masters seem mysterious. All we can describe is their manner. They took care with every action, Watched like a hawk, Respected all, Adapted to every situation; and were firm inside so their clarity was always evident.

Chapter 15

David Hong Cheng

A good practitioner of Tao of old is:

A man of subtlety with deep insight,

But it is too profound to understand

Simply because he cannot be understood, one has to describe him as follow:

Cautious, like one crossing a frozen stream in winter;

Hesitant, like one fearing his surrounding neighbours;

Reserved, like a polite guest;

Supple, like ice about to melt;

Chapter 15

Ellen Marie Chen

Those in the past who were good at practicing Tao,

Were subtle, mysterious, dark, penetrating (wei miao yüan t'ung),

Deep and unrecognizable.

Because they were unrecognizable,

I am forced to describe their appearance (yung).

Careful, like crossing a river in winter,

Hesitating, like fearing neighbors on four sides,

Reverent, like being guests,

Dissolving, like ice beginning to melt,

Open, like a valley. Mixing freely, like muddy water.

Calm the muddy water, It becomes clear. Move the inert, It comes to life.?

Those who sustain Tao Do not wish to be full. Because they do not wish to be full They can fade away Without further effort.

melt,

Self-effacing!

Like a wood-block untouched by a tool,

How sincere!

Like a valley awaiting a guest,

How receptive!

Like a torrent that rushes along,

And so turbid!

Who, running dirty, comes clean like still waters?

Who, being quiet, moves others to fullness of life?

It is he who, embracing the Way, is not greedy;

Who endures wear and tear without needing renewal.

Practice stilling the mind amidst everyday life, till it clears. Remain unmoved till the movement comes of its own accord.

Don't try to fulfill the Tao, but remain empty. Only by being empty can you be filled.

of of virgin wood;

Open-minded, like a valley; and

Confused, like muddy water.

Who can get rid of the muddiness?

It gradually clears though stillness.

Who can revitalize it after long stillness?

It gradually returns to life through activities.

A practitioner of Tao has no desire for filling to brim.

Just because of no filling to the brim,

He will not be worn out but be renewed.

like a valley,

Chaotic (hun), like murky (cho) water.

What can stop the murkiness?

Quieting (ching) down, gradually it clarifies (ch'ing).

What can keep still for long?

Moving, gradually it stirs into life.

Those who keep this Tao,

Do not want to be filled to the full (ying).

Because they are not full,

They can renew (hsin) themselves before being worn out (pi).

Chapter 16

Addiss & Lombardo

Chapter 16

Raymond B. Blakney

Chapter 16

David Bullen

Chapter 16

David Hong Cheng

Chapter 16

Ellen Marie Chen

Attain complete emptiness, Hold fast to stillness.

The ten thousand things stir about; I only watch for their going back. Things grow and grow, But each goes back to its root.

Going back to the root is stillness. This means returning to what is.

Touch ultimate emptiness,
Hold steady and still.

All things work together:

I have watched them reverting,

And have seen how they flourish

And return again, each to his roots.

This, I say, is the stillness:

A retreat to one's roots;

Or better yet, return

To the will of God,

Which is, I say, to constancy.

The

Empty the mind by not thinking of gain or loss. Follow your heart in all matters and the mind isn't stirred. Even though the misery of others is apparent, you contemplate their ultimate destiny. That destiny is enlightenment. Being one with the Tao is enlightenment.

Attain the utmost emptiness of mind,
Maintain the utmost stillness.

While all things are simultaneously developing,

I can observe their cycles.

Though everything is flourishing, each will return to its root,

Returning to the root means stillness, and

Stillness marks the cycle of life.

The cycle of life is an eternal truth,

Reach the pole of emptiness (hsü-chi),

Abide in genuine quietude (ching).

Ten thousand beings flourish together,

I am to contemplate (kuan) their return (fu).

Now things grow profusely,

Each again returns (kuei) to its root.

To return to the root is to attain quietude (ching),

It is called to recover life (ming).

To recover life is to attain the Everlasting (ch'ang),

To know the Everlasting (ch'ang) is to be illumined (ming).

Returning to what is Means going back to the ordinary.

Understanding the ordinary:
Enlightenment. Not understanding the ordinary: Blindness creates evil.
Understanding the ordinary: Mind opens. Mind opening leads to compassion, Compassion to nobility, Nobility to heavenliness, Heavenliness to Tao.

Tao endures. Your body dies. There is no danger.

knowledge of constancy

I call enlightenment and say

That not to know it

Is blindness that works evil.

But when you know

What eternally is so,

You have stature

And stature means righteousness

And righteousness is kingly

And kingliness divine

And divinity is the Way

Which is final.

Then, though you die,

You shall not perish.

Here you are serenely impartial. Being someone is a delusion. Here you are separate and confused. Impartial, you shine on existence like the sun, caring not what or who you shine on. At one with the Tao, birth and death cannot touch you.

Knowing the truth is called enlightenment,

Not knowing the truth and acting blindly results in disaster.

Knowing the truth enhances forbearance,

Forbearance leads to objectivity,

Objectivity becomes the universal rule,

The universal rule is in accord with Nature, and

Nature is in harmony with Tao.

Tao is everlasting, and

Not knowing (chih) the Everlasting (ch'ang),

One commits evils wantonly.

Knowing the Everlasting one becomes all containing (yung).

To be all containing is to be public (kung).

To be public is to be kingly (wang).

To be kingly is to be like heaven.

To be like heaven is to be like Tao.

To be like Tao is to last long.

This is to lose the body without becoming exhausted (pu tai).

Chapter 17

Addiss & Lombardo

Chapter 17

Raymond B. Blakney

Chapter 17

David Bullen

Chapter 17

David Hong Cheng

Chapter 17

Ellen Marie Chen

Great rising and falling - People only know it exists. Next they see and praise. Soon they fear. Finally they despise. Without fundamental trust There is no trust at all.

As for him who is highest,
The people just know he is there.
His deputy's cherished and praised;
Of the third, they are frightened;
The fourth, they despise and revile.
If you trust people less than enough,
Some

The master of the Tao is the highest.
The next is the person who causes others to love him.
The next is the person who causes others to fear him.
The lowest is the person who causes others to despise him.

The best ruler, the people only know of his existence;
The next best, the people praise and want to be near him;
The next, the people fear him;
The last, the people despise him.
If

The best government, the people know it is just there.
The next best, they love and praise it.
The next, they fear it.
The next, they revile against it.
When you

Be careful in valuing words.
When the work is done, Everyone says We just acted naturally.

of them never trust you.
He is aloof, as if his talk
Were priced beyond the purchasing;
But once his project is contrived,
The folk will want to say of it:
"Of course! We did it by ourselves!"

The master trusts in the Tao, therefore doesn't try to improve others.
Limited in his words, he lets his actions speak loudly. Others begin following his actions and success comes naturally.

there is not enough faith,
There will be no faith.
The best ruler is so relaxed, he hardly talks.
When he successfully completes his work,
People all say that for us, it is only natural.

don't trust (hsin) [the people] enough,
Then they are untrustworthy (pu hsin).
Quiet, why value words (yen)?
Work is accomplished, things are done.
People all say that I am natural (tzu-jan).

Chapter 18

Addiss & Lombardo

Chapter 18

Raymond B. Blakney

Chapter 18

David Bullen

Chapter 18

David Hong Cheng

Chapter 18

Ellen Marie Chen

Great Tao rejected:
Benevolence and
righteousness appear.

Learning and
knowledge
professed: Great
Hypocrites spring

The mighty Way
declined among the
folk

And then came
kindness and
morality.

When wisdom and
intelligence
appeared,

They brought with
them a great
hypocrisy.

The

When people are
separated from the
Tao, they are taught
to be kind and
ethical. Given
intellectual
knowledge they lose
their intelligence.

When the great Tao
declines,

Then humanity and
justice arise.

When knowledge and
cleverness appear,

The great hypocrisy
follows.

When the six family

On the decline of the
great Tao,

There are humanity
(jen) and
righteousness (i).

When intelligence
(hui) and knowledge
(chih) appear,

There is great
artificiality (wei).

When the

up.

Family relations
forgotten: Filial piety
and affection arise.

The nation
disordered: Patriots
come forth.

six relations were no
more at peace,

So codes were made
to regulate our
homes.

The fatherland grew
dark, confused by
strife:

Official loyalty
became the style.

They are trained to
be obedient and
polite to make them
consistent. Only by
suppressing their
individuality will
they serve abstract
concepts, such as a
country.

relationships are in
disharmony,

Then filial piety and
parental love
strengthen.

When a state is in
disorderly crisis,

The loyal ministers
stand out.

six relations are not
in harmony,

There are filial piety
(hsiao) and parental
love (tz'u).

When a nation is in
darkness (hun) and
disorder (lüan),

There are loyal
ministers.

Chapter 19

Addiss & Lombardo

Chapter 19

Raymond B. Blakney

Chapter 19

David Bullen

Chapter 19

David Hong Cheng

Chapter 19

Ellen Marie Chen

Banish learning,
discard knowledge:
People will gain a
hundredfold.

Banish benevolence,
discard
righteousness: People
will return to duty
and compassion.

Banish skill, discard
profit: There will

Get rid of the wise
men!

Put out the
professors!

Then people will
profit
A hundredfold over.

Away with the kind
ones;

Those righteous men
too!

And let people return
To the graces of
home.

Root out the artisans;
Banish the profiteers!

Ideas of holiness and
wisdom will hamper
your progress. Ideas
of morality and
justice cannot replace
what is written on
people's hearts. The
idea of profiting off
others causes thieves
to appear.

Reject sageness and
abandon knowledge,
The people will
benefit a
hundredfold.

Reject humanity and
abandon justice,
The people will
return to filial piety
and parental love.

Reject cleverness and
abandon profit,

Eliminate sagacity
(sheng), discard
knowledge (chih),
People will be
profited (li) a
hundredfold.

Eliminate humanity
(jen), discard
righteousness (i),
People will again
practice filial piety
and parental love.

Abolish artistry
(ch'iao), discard
profit-seeking (li),
Robbers and thieves
shall disappear.

be no more thieves.

These three
statements are not
enough. One more
step is necessary.

Look at plain silk;
hold uncarved wood.
The self dwindles;
desires fade.

And bandits and
robbers
Will not come to
plunder.

But if these three
prove not enough
To satisfy the mind
and heart,
More relevant, then,
let there be
A visible simplicity
of life,
Embracing
unpretentious ways,
And small
self-interest
And poverty of
coveting.

Since these three
ideas are man made,
they are not eternal.
Therefore they
should be avoided.
Patient,
compassionate, and
desireless, you are in
step with the Tao.

Robbers and thieves
will disappear.

These three are
insufficient to form a
doctrine.

Let there be
something for the
people to commit to:
Be plain and simple,
and
Curtail selfishness
and desires.

These three pairs
adorn (wen) what is
deficient (pu tsu).

Therefore, let there
be the advice:
Look to the undyed
silk, hold on to the
uncarved wood (p'u),
Reduce your sense of
self (szu) and lessen
your desires (yü).

Banish learning, no
more grief. Between
Yes and No How
much difference?
Between good and
evil How much
difference??

What others fear I
must fear - How
pointless!

People are wreathed
in smiles As if at a
carnival banquet. I
alone am passive,
giving no sign, Like
an infant who has not
yet smiles.

Be done with rote learning
And its attendant
vexations;
For is there distinction
Of a "yes" from a "yea"
Comparable now to the
gulf

Between evil and good?

"What all men fear, I too
must fear"-

How barren and pointless
a thought!

The reveling of multitudes

At the feast of Great
Sacrifice,

Or up on the terrace

At carnival in spring,

Leave me, alas, unmoved,
alone,

Like a child that has never
smiled.

Lazily, I drift

Without thinking,
you cannot worry.
There is nothing
good or bad. You can
neither succeed nor
fail. The master may
still think of good or
bad, but he is aware
that it is a thought
and simply watches it
pass. An ordinary
man thinks of good
or bad and believes
it. This is the
difference between
enlightenment and
delusion. Ordinary
people try different
hobbies in the pursuit
of happiness. The
master drifts around
doing nothing in
particular, indifferent
like a baby before it
can smile.

Abandon learning, then
you will have no
worldly concerns.

What difference is
there between yes and
no? Good and evil?

What people dread,
must I also dread?

How confusing! And
there is no end to it yet!

The people are merry,
like feasting at grand
Sacrifices,

Or ascending a
ceremonial tower in the
Spring.

Uninvolved like an
infant yet to giggle;

So weary, like a
homeless person!

All the people have
enough to spare, I

Eliminate (chüeh) learning
so as to have no worries,

Yes and no, how far apart
are they?

Good and evil, how far
apart are they?

What the sages (jen) fear,

I must not not fear.

I am the wilderness (huang)
before the dawn (wei yang).

The multitude (chung jen)
are busy and active,

Like partaking of the
sacrificial feast,

Like ascending the platform
in spring;

I alone (tu) am bland (p'o),

As if I have not yet
emerged (chao) into form.

Like an infant who has not
yet smiled (hai),

Lost, like one who has
nowhere to return

Forlorn as if I had no
home.

Others have enough
and more, I alone am
left out. I have the
mind of a fool,
Confused, confused.

Others are bright and
intelligent, I alone
and dull, dull,
Drifting on the
ocean, Blown about
endlessly.

Others have plans, I
alone am wayward
and stubborn, I alone
am different from
others, Like a baby in
the womb.

had no home.

All others have enough to
spare;

I am the one left out.

I have the mind of a fool,
Muddled and confused!

When common people
scintillate

I alone make shadows.

Vulgar folks are sharp and
knowing:

Only I am melancholy.

Restless like the ocean,

Blown about, I cannot
stop.

Other men can find
employment,

But I am stubborn; I am
mean.

Alone I am and different,

Because I prize and seek

Ordinary people have
an identity. The
master has none.
Therefore he seems
like an idiot.
Ordinary people try
to shine outwardly
through their
achievements. The
master's
achievements are not
known by others. The
intentions of ordinary
people are evident.
The master has no
intentions. Ordinary
people know what to
do. The master
doesn't. He drifts
along like a cloud in
the sky. He is
different from
ordinary people. He
is nourished by the
Tao.

alone seem to be left
out;

So unconcerned, as if I
have a mind of an
ignorant man.

Common folks are
clear-minded, I alone
seem to be mindless!

Common folks are
seriously engaged, I
alone seem to be
wandering:

Drifting like the vast
sea; and

Aimless, like the long
wind.

All the people are
purposeful, I alone and
stubborn and out of
step.

I alone differ from
others, but do value
being sustained by the
Mother.

(wu so kuei).

The multitudes (chung jen)
all have too much (yu yü);

I alone (tu) am deficient (i).

My mind (hsin) is that of a
fool (yü),

Nebulous.

Worldly people (su jen) are
luminous (chao);

I alone (tu) am dark (hun).

Worldly people are
clear-sighted (ch'a);

I alone (tu) am dull (men),

I am calm like the sea,

Like the high winds I never
stop (chih).

The multitudes (chung jen)
all have their use (i);

I alone (tu) am untamable
like lowly material.

I alone (tu) am different
from others.

For I treasure feeding on
the Mother (mu).

Chapter 21

Addiss & Lombardo

Chapter 21

Raymond B. Blakney

Chapter 21

David Bullen

Chapter 21

David Hong Cheng

Chapter 21

Ellen Marie Chen

Great Te appears
Flowing from Tao.

Tao in action - Only
vague and intangible.
Intangible and vague,
But within it are
images. Vague and
intangible; Within
are entities.

The omnipresent
Virtue will take
shape

According only to
the Way.

The Way itself is like
some thing

Seen in a dream,
elusive, evading one.

In it are images,
elusive, evading one.

In it are things like
shadows in twilight.

The master has
separated from mind,
and the great virtuous
Tao is. The mind is
like a foot. If it
follows that which is
greater it is useful. If
it tries to lead of its
own volition it will
lead to disaster.

Creation of
everything in the
universe follows only
Tao.

The material universe
created by Tao seems
unclear and blurred:

So blurred and so
unclear, yet in it
there are images;

So unclear and so
blurred, yet in it there
are things;

So dim and so
invisible, yet

The features (yung)
of the vast (k'ung)
Te,

Follows entirely
(wei) from Tao.

Tao as a thing,

Is entirely illusive
(huang) and evasive
(hu).

Evasive and illusive,

In it there is image
(hsiang).

Illusive and evasive,

In it there is
thinghood (wu).

Dark and dim,

In it there is life seed
(ching).

Its life seed being

Shadowy and
obscure; Within there
is life, Life so real,
That within it there is
trust.

From the beginning
its name is not lost
But reappears
through multiple
origins.

How do I know these
origins? Like this.

In it are essences,
subtle but real,
Embedded in truth.

From of old until
now,

Under names without
end,

The First, the
Beginning is seen.

How do I know the
beginning of all,

What its nature may
be?

By these!

The Tao is beyond
conception, so drop
all ideas. If you cling
to anything it cannot
provide nourishment.
Neither inside nor
outside, the Tao is
non-dual. It can only
be known by not
knowing.

in it there is essence.

The essence is very
real, and in it there is
evidence.

From the beginning
until now, the
naming has never
stopped.

So the beginning of
many things may be
understood.

How do I know the
many situations at
the beginning?

Through this.

very genuine (chen),

In it there is growth
power (hsin).

As it is today, so it
was in the days of old
(ku),

Its name goes not
away (ch'ü),

So that we may
survey (yüeh) the
origins of the many
(chung fu).

How do I know that
the origins of the
many are such?

Because of this.

Crippled become whole, Crooked becomes straight, Hollow becomes full, Worn becomes new, Little becomes more, Much becomes delusion.

Therefore the Sages cling to the One And take care of this world;

Do not display themselves And therefore shine.

The crooked shall be made straight

And the rough places plain;

The pools shall be filled

And the worn renewed;

The needy shall receive

And the rich shall be perplexed.

So the Wise Man cherishes the One,

As a standard to the world:

Not displaying himself,

He is famous;

Not asserting himself,

He is

Separate yourself and become whole. Yield and become firm. Be empty so you can be filled. Die so you can be reborn. Lose everything you have, and have it all. The master through the Tao sets and example for all. He doesn't show off so his depth is evident.

To yield is to be preserved whole,

To be bent is to become straight,

To be low is to be filled,

To be worn is to be renewed,

To have little is to gain,

To have too much is to be confused.

Thus the sage embraces the One,

And becomes a model for the world.

He does not:

Insist on his own views,

Bent, thus (tse) preserved whole,

Unjustly accused, thus exonerated (chih),

Hollow, thus filled (ying),

Battered (pi), thus renewed,

Scanty, thus receiving (te),

Much, thus perplexed.

Therefore the sage embraces the One (pao i).

He becomes the model (shih) of the world.

Do not assert themselves and therefore stand out. Do not praise themselves And therefore succeed.

Do not contend And therefore no one under heaven Can contend with them.

The old saying Crippled becomes whole Is not empty words. It becomes whole and returns.

distinguished;

Not boasting his powers,

He is effective;

Taking no pride in himself,

He is chief.

Because he is no competitor,

No one in all the world

can compete with him.

The saying of the men of old

Is not in vain:

"The crooked shall be made straight-"

To be perfect, return to it.

Free from ambition, he can be trusted. Having lost his identity, people can identify with him. Never disagreeing, no one can disagree with him. When the ancient masters said: "Separate yourself and become whole", they weren't doing so lightly. Trust the masters and become whole.

thus he has a clear view;

Justify himself, thus he sees the truth;

Boast of his achievements, thus he is given credit;

Become arrogant, thus grows in stature.

Simply because he is not contentious,

No one in the world can contend against him.

Is the ancient saying to yield is to be preserved whole, empty words?

It is truly perfect and should be preserved.

self-justifying, hence he is

outstanding.

Not showing off (fa) his deeds, hence he is meritorious.

Not boasting (ching) of himself, hence he leads (chang).

Because he is not contentious (pu cheng),

Hence no one under heaven can contend with him.

What the ancients say: "Bent, thus preserved whole,"

Are these empty words?

Chapter 23

Addiss & Lombardo

Chapter 23

Raymond B. Blakney

Chapter 23

David Bullen

Chapter 23

David Hong Cheng

Chapter 23

Ellen Marie Chen

Spare words; nature's way. Violent winds do not blow all morning. Sudden rain cannot pour all day.

What causes these things? Heaven and Earth. If Heaven and Earth do not blow and pour for long, How much less should humans?

Therefore in following Tao: Those on the

Sparing indeed is nature of its talk:

The whirlwind will not last the morning out;

The cloudburst ends before the day is done.

What is it that behaves itself like this?

The earth and sky!
And if it be that these

Cut short their speech, how much more yet should man!

If you work by the Way,

You will be of the

Wa —

y —

;

To be limited in speech is natural. Clouds may come, but when they pass the sun shines through. Your words may come, but when they pass there is silence. This is the natural way of the Tao. When things come, let them.

Nature utters few words.

Thus:

Violent winds seldom last for a whole morning,

Pouring rains rarely persist for a full day.

Who is responsible? Heaven and Earth.

Even Heaven and Earth do not persist for long, how should human beings?

Therefore the practitioner of Tao knows that:

He who follows Tao identifies with the follower of Tao;

He —

Nature speaks (yen) little.

Hence a squall lasts not a whole morning,

A rainstorm continues not a whole day.

What causes (wei) these?

Heaven and earth.

Even [the actions of] heaven and earth do not last long,

How much less [the works] of humans?

Therefore one who follows Tao identifies with Tao,

One who follows te (nature) identifies

way become the way, Those who gain become the gain, Those who lose become the loss.

All within the Tao: The wayfarer, welcome upon the way, Those who gain, welcome within gain, Those who lose, welcome withon loss.

Without trust in this, There is no trust at all.

If you work through its virtue

you will be given the virtue;

Abandon either one

And both abandon you.

Gladly then the Way receives

Those who choose to walk in it;

Gladly too its power upholds

Those who choose to use it well;

Gladly will abandon greet

Those who to abandon drift.

Little faith is put in them

When things pass, let them. Following the natural flow you will embody the Tao. Virtue can be experienced by the virtuous. Those who lose the natural way become lost. If you don't trust in your natural responses, you make yourself untrustworthy.

who is virtuous identifies with the person of virtue;

He who lost faith identifies with the faithless.

He who is identified with Tao, the follower of Tao is also happy to be with him;

He who is virtuous, the person of virtue is also happy to be with him;

He who is faithless, the faithless person is also happy to be with him.

He who has not enough faith in others commands no faith from others.

with te (nature).

One who follows shih (loss) identifies with shih.

One who identifies with Tao is glad to be with Tao.

One who identifies with te is glad to be with te.

One who identifies with shih is glad to be with shih.

When you don't trust (hsin) (the people) enough,

Then they are untrustworthy (pu hsin).

Chapter 24

Addiss & Lombardo

Chapter 24

Raymond B. Blakney

Chapter 24

David Bullen

Chapter 24

David Hong Cheng

Chapter 24

Ellen Marie Chen

Upon tiptoe: no way to stand. Clambering: no way to walk.

Self-display: no way to shine.

Self-assertion: no way to succeed.

Self-praise: no way to flourish.

On tiptoe your stance is unsteady;

Long strides make your progress unsure;

Show off and you get no attention;

Your boasting will mean you have failed;

Asserting yourself brings no credit;

Be proud

Strive for more, and you lose what you have. Hurry ahead and you will miss something, and then have to go back.

Boast of achievements, and they will be lost.

He who stands on tiptoe to be tall is unstable;

He who straddles to be fast is slow.

He who insists on his own views has no clear view;

He who justifies his own errors sees no truth.

He who boasts

One who tiptoes cannot stand.

One who straddles cannot walk.

One who sees himself is not enlightened (ming).

One who justifies himself is not outstanding.

One who shows off (fa) his deeds is not meritorious.

One who

Complacency: no way to endure.

According to Tao, Excessive food, Extraneous activity Inspire disgust. Therefore the follower of Tao Moves on.

and you will never lead.

To persons of the Way, these traits

Can only bring distrust; they seem

Like extra food for parasites.

So those who choose the Way,

Will never give them place.

Define who you are, and you will lose your true self. Try to control others, and you will be controlled by them.

These traits represent wasted energy spent on the ego. The master has long done away with them.

of his own achievements harms his credibility;

He who is arrogant experiences no growth in wisdom.

From the point of view of Tao,

They are like spoiled food and acts of nuisance which all detest.

Therefore followers of Tao avoid them.

boasts (ching) of himself does not lead (chang).

These to a Taoist are called:

Excess nature (yü te) and superfluous actions (shui hsing),

Avoided (o) even by things.

Therefore the Taoist does not indulge (ch'u) in them.

Chapter 25

Addiss & Lombardo

Chapter 25

Raymond B. Blakney

Chapter 25

David Bullen

Chapter 25

David Hong Cheng

Chapter 25

Ellen Marie Chen

Something unformed
and complete Before
heaven and Earth
were born, Solitary
and silent, Stands
alone and
unchanging.
Pervading all things
without limit. It is
like the mother of all
things under heaven,
But I don't know its
name - Better call it
Tao. Better call it
great.

Something there is,
whose veiled creation
was
Before the earth or
sky began to be;
So silent, so aloof
and so alone,
It changes not, nor
fails, but touches all:
Conceive it as the
mother of the world.
I do not know its
name:
A name for it is
"Way";
Pressed for
designation,
I call it Great.
Great means
outgoing,

Before the universe
was manifest a
perfect emptiness
abided. It is eternally
still and silent, but
creates infinite
things. Not having a
name, I call it the
Tao. Being
indescribable, I call it
great. Infinite things
constantly flow
through it, never
ceasing.

There was a chaotic
formation of matter,
Before the existence
of Heaven and Earth.
It was so noiseless,
so shapeless, all
alone and
unchanging,
It is moving around
endlessly.
It can be the mother
of Heaven and Earth.
I do not know its
name, but call it Tao.
If I must I name it
Great Reality.
Being

There was something
nebulous existing (yu
wu hun ch'eng),
Born before heaven and
earth.
Silent, empty,
Standing alone (tu),
altering not (pu kai),
Moving cyclically
without becoming
exhausted (pu tai),
Which may be called
the mother of all under
heaven.
I know not its name,
I give its alias (tzu),
Tao.
If forced to picture it,
I say it is "great" (ta).
To say it is "great" is to
say it is

Great means passing
on. Passing on means
going far. Going far
means returning.
Therefore Tao is
great, And heaven,
And earth, And
humans. Four great
things in the world.
Aren't humans one of
them?
Humans follow earth
Earth follows heaven
Heaven follows Tao.
Tao follows its own
nature.

Outgoing,
far-reaching,
Far-reaching, return.
The Way is great,
The sky is great,
The earth is great,
The king also is
great.
Within the realm
These four are great;
The king but stands
For one of them.
Man conforms to the
earth;
The earth conforms
to the sky;
The sky conforms to
the Way;

The Tao is great, The
universe is great, The
earth is great, Man is
great. Man must
follow the natural
laws of the earth, The
earth must follow the
natural laws of the
universe, The
universe must follow
the natural laws of
the Tao, The Tao
simply is.

great means
receding,
Receding means
going faraway and
Being faraway is
followed by
returning to the
origin.
Therefore,
Tao is great, Heaven
is great, Earth is
great and Humanity
is also great.
There are four great
realities in the
universe, and
Humanity is one of
them.
Humanity follows
the Earth;
Earth, Heaven;

"moving away" (shih),
To say it is "moving
away" is to say it is "far
away" (yüan),
To say it is "far away"
is to say it is
"returning" (fan).
Therefore Tao is great,
Heaven is great,
Earth is great,
The king is also great.
In the realm there are
four greats,
And the king is one of
them.
Humans follow (fa)
earth,
Earth follows heaven,
Heaven follows Tao,
Tao follows
self-becoming
(tzu-jan).

Chapter 26

Addiss & Lombardo

Chapter 26

Raymond B. Blakney

Chapter 26

David Bullen

Chapter 26

David Hong Cheng

Chapter 26

Ellen Marie Chen

Gravity is the root of
lightness, Stillness
the master of passion.

The Sage travels all
day But does not
leave the
baggage-cart; When
surrounded by

The heavy is
foundation for the
light;

So quietness is
master of the deed.

The Wise Man,
though he travel all
the day,

Will not be separated
from his goods.

So even if the scene
is glorious to view,

He keeps his

Something can only
be heavy relative to
something lighter.
Movement can only
occur relative to
something unmoved.
The master may
travel all day, but
remains motionless.
There may be
amazing sights, but
he never looks.

Heavy objects
provide footing for
the lighter ones,

Calm disposition
exerts control over
restlessness.

The wise ruler travels
all day without
leaving his heavy
supplies.

Even at the
magnificent sights,

The heavy (chung) is
root (ken) to the light
(ch'ing);

The tranquil (ching)
is master (chün) to
the agitated (tsao).

Therefore the sage
travels all day,

Without leaving (li)
his baggage wagon
(tzu chung).

Although he has
glorious

magnificent scenery
Remains calm and
still.

When a lord of ten
thousand chariots
Behaves lightly in
this world,

Lightness loses its
root, Passion loses its
master.

place, at peace,
above it all.

For how can one who
rules

Ten thousand
chariots

Give up to lighter
moods

AS all the world may
do?

If he is trivial,

His ministers are
lost;

If he is strenuous,

There is no master
then.

A father shouldn't act
the fool, and ignore
the needs of his
family. If you take
your responsibilities
lightly, you lose the
basis of your being.
If you fall prey to
restlessness you
cannot be relaxed.

he remain relaxed
and unperturbed.

Why than the lord of
ten thousand chariots
appear light-headed
in public?

Being light-headed
reflects the loss of
footing,

Being restless
signifies the loss of
control.

palaces (yung kuan),

He avoids its
sumptuous
apartments
(yen-ch'u).

How could the Lord
of ten thousand
chariots,

Conduct himself
lightly in the world?

One who acts lightly
loses his foundation
(pen);

One who is agitated
loses his master
(chün).

Chapter 27

Addiss & Lombardo

Chapter 27

Raymond B. Blakney

Chapter 27

David Bullen

Chapter 27

David Hong Cheng

Chapter 27

Ellen Marie Chen

Good travelers leave no tracks. Good words leave no trace. Good counting needs no markers.

Good doors have no bolts Yet cannot be forced. Good knots have no rope But cannot be untied.

In this way the Sage Always helps people And rejects none, Always helps all beings, And rejects none.

A good runner leaves no tracks.

A good speech has no flaws to censure.

A good computer uses no tallies.

A good door is well shut without bolts and cannot be opened.

A good knot is tied without rope and cannot be loosed.

The Wise Man is always good at helping people, so that none are cast out; he is

The master travels the natural path, which has no destination, and on which no tracks can be left. A good trader follows the market wherever it goes. A good teacher lets the students guide him. A master is present for all, both saints and sinners. All situations are used and nothing is dismissed.

An excellent walker leaves no track;

An excellent speech contains no flaw;

An excellent reckoner uses no counter;

A well-shut door uses no mechanism, yet none can open it;

A well-tied know uses no rope, yet none can untie it.

Similarly,

The sage always excels in saving people, thus there is no useless people.

The sage always excels in saving

Good (shan) running leaves no tracks,

Good speech has no flaws,

Good counting uses no counters,

A good lock uses no bolts yet cannot be opened,

A good knot uses no rope yet cannot be untied.

Hence the sage is always good at saving people,

Therefore no one is rejected.

He is always good at saving

This is called practicing brightness.

Therefore the good person is the bad person's teachers, And the bad person Is the good person's resource.

Not to value the teacher, Not to love the resource, Causes great confusion even for the intelligent. This is called the vital secret.

always good at saving things,

so that none are thrown away.

This is called applied intelligence.

Surely the good man is the bad man's teacher;

and the bad man is the good man's business.

If the one does not respect his teacher, or the other doesn't love his business,

his error is very great.

This is indeed an important secret.

This is called spreading the light. A man, who considers himself good, must be intimate with that which is bad. A man, who considers himself bad, must know the good. Therefore the master sees no distinction between the two. For this reason the master and disciple are equal.

things, thus there is no abandoned thing.

This is called the innate enlightenment.

It follows that:

A superior person if the teacher of the lesser person, and

The lesser person provides lessons for the superior person.

The person who does not value his teacher, nor care about the lessons,

Is deeply confused despite the person's intelligence.

This is an important subtlety.

things,

Therefore nothing is rejected.

This is called following the light (ming).

Therefore the good person,

Is the not-good (pu-shan) person's teacher.

The not-good (pu-shan) person,

Is the good person's capital.

One who does not honor (kuei) the teacher,

Or love (ai) the capital,

Is greatly confounded though knowledgeable (chih).

Chapter 28

Addiss & Lombardo

Chapter 28

Raymond B. Blakney

Chapter 28

David Bullen

Chapter 28

David Hong Cheng

Chapter 28

Ellen Marie Chen

Know the male,
maintain the female,
Become the channel
of the world, And Te
will endure. Return
to infancy.

Know the white,
sustain the black,
Become the pattern
of the world, And Te
will not falter.

Be aware of your
masculine nature;
But by keeping the
feminine way,

You shall be to the
world like a canyon,

Where the Virtue
eternal abides,

And go back to
become as a child.

Be aware of the white
all around you;

But remembering the
black that is there,

You shall be to the
world like a tester,

Whom the Virtue
eternal, unerring,

Redirects to the

Know how to be
assertive but remain
passive. Be receptive
towards all situations
and you will be in
accordance with
them, like a little
child. Understanding
the conditionality of
opposites, you can
avoid all opposition.
Never in error, you
are virtuous. People
are bound to follow
such and example.

He who knows the
male, yet keeps to the
female,

Is like the ravine of
the world.

Being the ravine of
the world,

He never departs from
the eternal virtue, and

Returns to the state of
harmony with Nature
as in infancy.

He who knows the
white, yet keeps to the
black,

Is the model for the
world.

Being the model for
the world,

He never deviates
from the eternal
virtue, and

To know (chih) the
male,

But to abide (shou) by
the female (tz'u),

Is to be the valley (ch'i)
of the world.

Being the valley of the
world,

And departing (li) not
from the everlasting
power (ch'ang te),

One again returns to the
infant (ying erh).

To know (chih) the
white (pe),

But to abide (shou) by
the black (heh),

Is to be the model (shih)
of the world.

Being the model of the
world,

And deviating (t'eh) not

Return to the
uncarved block.

Know honour,
sustain disgrace,
Become the valley of
the world, And Te
will prevail. Return
to simplicity.

Simplicity divided
becomes utensils
That are used by the
Sage as high official.
But great governing
does not carve up.

infinite past.

Be aware of your
glory and honor;

But in never
relinquishing shame,

You shall be to the
world like a valley,

Where Virtue eternal,
sufficient,

Sends you back to the
Virginal Block.

When the Virginal
Block is asunder,

And is made into
several tools,

To the ends of the
Wise Man directed,

They become then his
chief officers:

For "The Master
himself does not
carve."

Know the personal,
but keep to the
impersonal: Accept
the world as it is. If
you accept the world
as it is you will
naturally be humble.
How can the
impersonal be
arrogant? In this way
the master is like a
block of wood, which
can be carved into
any shape.

the state of
selflessness as in
primordial times.

He who knows glory,
but keeps to humility,

Is like the valley of
the world.

Being the valley of the
world, he is sufficient
in the eternal virtue,
and

Returns to the sate of
natural goodness like
virgin blocks.

When the blocks are
dispersed and found
useful as tools,

The wise ruler
employs them to
govern and lead.

Therefore the great
leader does not
destroy Nature.

from the everlasting
power,

One again returns to the
unlimited (wu-chi).

To know (chih) the
illustrious (yung),

But to abide (shou) by
the obscure (ju),

Is to be the valley (ku) of
the world.

Being the valley of the
world,

One's everlasting power
(ch'ang te) being full,

One again returns to the
uncarved wood (p'u).

The uncarved wood
disperses to become
vessels (ch'i),

To be used (yung) by the
sage as officials.

Therefore a great
institution does not
mutilate (ko).

Chapter 29

Addiss & Lombardo

Chapter 29

Raymond B. Blakney

Chapter 29

David Bullen

Chapter 29

David Hong Cheng

Chapter 29

Ellen Marie Chen

Trying to control the world? I see you won't succeed.

The world is a spiritual vessel And cannot be controlled. Those who control, fail. Those who grasp, lose.

Some go

As for those who would take the whole world

To tinker as they see fit,

I observe that they never succeed:

For the world is a sacred vessel

Not to be altered by man.

The tinker will spoil it;

Usurpers will lose it.

For indeed there are things

That

You cannot change the world, only yourself. The world is in constant natural change, how could you add to it? If you try to change it you will ruin yourself. If you treat it like an object, you objectify yourself. Simply follow the natural flow of the changes: Sometimes lead, Sometimes follow, Sometimes move, Sometimes stop, Sometimes be active, Sometimes be at rest, Sometimes be safe, Sometimes be in danger.

Whoever intends to conquer the empire through willful actions,

I foresee that he will not succeed.

The empire is a complex organism, no willful action should be taken.

He who so acts fails.

He who so exerts

One who desires to take the world and act (wei) upon it,

I see that it cannot be done.

The world (t'ien hsia) is a spirit vessel (shen ch'i),

Which cannot be acted (wei) upon.

One who acts (wei) on it fails,

One who holds on

forth, some are led, Some weep, some blow flutes, Some become strong, some superfluous, Some oppress, some are destroyed.

Therefore the Sage Casts off extremes, Casts off excess, Casts off Extravagance.

must move ahead,

While others must lag;

And some that feel hot,

While others feel cold;

And some that are strong,

While others are weak;

And vigorous ones,

While others worn out.

So the Wise Man discards

Extreme inclinations

To make sweeping judgments,

Or to a life of excess.

The master knows the world is beyond his control, so lets things come and go without interfering. He is like a blade of grass: When the wind blows it bends with it. This way he is always centered and keeps his energy.

control loses it.

For, of all creatures: some lead, some follow;

some sigh, some complain;

some are strong, some are weak;

some suffer setbacks, some are already fallen.

Thus a wise ruler avoids extremes, extravagance, and excesses.

to it loses (shih).

Therefore things either move forward or follow behind;

They blow hot or blow cold;

They are strong (ch'iang) or weak;

They get on or they get off.

Therefore the sage gets rid of over-doing,

Gets rid of extravagances,

Gets rid of excesses.

Chapter 30

Addiss & Lombardo

Chapter 30

Raymond B. Blakney

Chapter 30

David Bullen

Chapter 30

David Hong Cheng

Chapter 30

Ellen Marie Chen

Use Tao to help rule people. This world has no need for weapons, Which soon turn on themselves.

Where armies camp, nettles grow. After each war, years of famine.

The most fruitful

To those who would help

The ruler of men

By means of the Way:

Let him not with his militant might

Try to conquer the world;

This tactic is like to recoil.

For where armies have marched,

There do briars spring up;

Where great hosts are impressed,

Years of hunger and evil ensue.

The good man's purpose once attained,

He stops at

A father who trusts in the Tao doesn't force his children to do anything, and doesn't discipline them. He knows this would be against the natural way and would damage the children as well as himself. The master knows if force is used on a child, weeds will grow in the child's mind.

He who assists a ruler through Tao,

Disavows dominating the world by military force.

The effects of using force are immediate:

Wherever the army is stationed, briars and thorns will grow.

(After a big war, years of famine will surely follow.)

The best leader cares only about an accommodation, and

One who assists the ruler with Tao,

Does not overpower (ch'iang) the world by military conquests.

Such affairs have a way of returning (huan):

Where armies are stationed,

Briars and thorns grow,

After great campaigns,

Bad years are sure to follow.

The good person is resolute (kuo) only,

But dares not (kan) take the path of the

outcome Does not depend on force,
But succeeds without arrogance Without hostility Without Pride Without resistance Without violence.

If these things prosper and grow old, This is called not-Tao. Not-Tao soon ends.

that;

He will not press for victory.

His point once made, he does not boast,

Or celebrate the goal he gained,

Or proudly indicate the spoils.

He won the day because he must:

But not by force or violence.

That things with age decline in strength,

You well may say, suits not the Way;

And not to suit the Way is early death.

Achievements may be apparent, but he will not boast or take pride in them. He knows they are attributed to the Tao, and no claimant exists. From here he simply moves on. This is the natural way.

Dares not to gain dominance by force.

An accommodation reached without conceit, brag, or arrogance; but on account of no better alternative and

reluctance of using force.

Everything decays after its prime,

This (using force) would be counter to Tao.

Whoever acts counter to Tao leads to his early demise.

strong (ch'iang).

Be resolute (kuo) yet do not boast (ching),

Be resolute yet do not show off (fa),

Be resolute yet do not be haughty,

Be resolute because you have no choice,

Be resolute yet do not overpower (ch'iang).

When things are full grown, they age.

This is called not following Tao.

Not following Tao they perish early.

Chapter 31

Addiss & Lombardo

Fine weapons are ill-omened tools. They are hated. Therefore the old Tao ignores them.

At home, honour the left. In war, honor the right.

Good omens honour the left. Bad omens honour the right. The lieutenant on the left, The general on the right As in funeral ceremonies.

Weapons are ill-omened, Not proper instruments.

Chapter 31

Raymond B. Blakney

Weapons at best are tools of bad omen,

Loathed and avoided by those of the Way.

In the usage of men of good breeding,

Honor is had at the left;

Good omens belong on the left

Bad omens belong on the right;

And warriors press to the right!

When the general stands at the right

His lieutenant is placed at the left.

So the usage of men of great power

Follows that of the funeral rite.

Weapons are tools of bad omen,

By gentlemen not to be used;

Chapter 31

David Bullen

Weapons generate fear; real humans loath them. Peace is the highest value. If it has been destroyed, utmost restraint is needed to restore it. Your enemies are people as well, so any battle is entered into gravely.

Chapter 31

David Hong Cheng

Weapons are tools of bad omen, everyone dislikes them,

Thus the follower of Tao keeps away from them.

A statesman normally honours his left;

But in war, he honours his right.

Weapons are tools of bad omen, and of no use to a statesman.

If forced to use them, it is best for him to be calm and restrained.

Glorify not the victory of war.

One who does, must be happy

Chapter 31

Ellen Marie Chen

Military weapons are implements (ch'i) of ill omen,

Avoided (o) even by natural creatures (wu).

Hence the Taoist does not indulge (ch'u) in them.

The princely person (chün-tzu) in dwelling honors the left,

In military campaigns honors the right.

Hence military weapons are not implements of a princely person.

Military weapons, being implements of ill omen,

Are to be employed only in dire necessity.

Better to regard them with lack of interest.

Do not admire (mei) them.

If one admires (mei) them,

When their use can't be avoided, Calm restraint is best. Don't think they are beautiful. Those who think they are beautiful Rejoice in killing people.

Those who rejoice in killing people Cannot achieve their purpose in this world.

When many people are killed We feel sorrow and grief. A great victory Is a funeral ceremony.

when it cannot be avoided,

They use them with calm and restraint.

Even in victory's hour

These tools are unlovely to see;

For those who admire them truly

Are men who in murder delight.

As for those who delight to do murder,

It is certain they never can get

From the world what they sought when ambition

Urged them to power and rule.

A multitude slain!- and their death

Is a matter for grief and for tears;

The victory after a conflict

Is a theme for a funeral rite.

Do not wish them personal harm. Do not rejoice in victory. Who would rejoice in the killing of men? Conduct a war as you would a funeral, it is a time of mourning. Weep for your enemy as you would for your friend.

to kill!

He who is happy to kill must not succeed in the world.

Auspicious occasions honour the left,

Evil occasions honour the right.

When the deputy general stays on the left,

While the full general stays on the right,

Declare that a funeral ceremony is taking place.

Since so many people are slaughtered,

Let us weep with deep sorrow and grief, and

Treat a victory celebration as a funeral ceremony.

in the killing of people.

But whoever rejoices in the killing of people,

Will not be successful (chih) in the world.

Therefore in joyful affairs the left is honored,

In mournful affairs the right is honored.

The Second-in-Command takes the place of the left,

The Commander-in-Chief takes the place of the right,

Meaning that this is his place in the funeral rite.

When many people have been killed,

Wail them with sorrow and lamentations.

When victorious in battle,

Mark the occasion with the rite (li) of funeral.

Chapter 32

Addiss & Lombardo

Chapter 32

Raymond B. Blakney

Chapter 32

David Bullen

Chapter 32

David Hong Cheng

Chapter 32

Ellen Marie Chen

Tao endures without a name. Though simple and slight, No one under heaven can master it.

If kings and lords could posses it, All beings would become their guests.

Heaven and earth together Would drip sweet dew Equally

The Way eternal has no name.

A block of wood untooled, though small,

May still excel the world.

And if the king and nobles could

Retain its potency for good,

Then everything would freely give

Allegiance to their rule.

The earth and sky would then conspire

To bring the sweet

The Tao is not big, but it contains all. If a father could follow the Tao, the children will be naturally compliant.

Everything will be in perfect accord, and life will be sweet. If you create laws, you create lawlessness. If you trust the people the law will be written on their hearts.

Tao is eternal and nameless.

Even though its singular building block is tiny,

None in the world can master over it.

If kings and barons keep faith in it,

All things spontaneously follow order.

When Heaven and Earth joined to make sweet dew,

It

Tao everlasting (ch'ang) is the nameless uncarved wood (p'u).

Though small,

Nothing under heaven can subjugate it (mo neng ch'en).

If kings and barons can abide by (shou) it,

All creatures will arrive as guests (pin) to a banquet.

Heaven and earth unite,

To send down the sweet rain.

Without being commanded by the people

on all people Without regulation.

Begin to make order and names arise. Names lead to more names - And to knowing when to stop.

Tao's presence in this world Is like valley streams Flowing into rivers and seas.

dew down;

And evenly it would be given

To folk without constraining power.

Creatures came to be with order's birth,

And once they had appeared,

Came also knowledge of repose,

And with that was security.

In this world,

Compare those of the Way

To torrents that flow Into river and sea.

When you name something, you create division. Institutions are created to serve a common purpose. When the purpose is served they are no longer needed. Know when to stop to avoid conflicts. Everything flows into the Tao, as all rivers flow into the ocean.

is evenly spread without the people's command.

Initiating regulations produces names.

Since names already proliferate, one must also know when to stop.

Knowing when to stop can avoid over regulation.

Tao to the world is like streams in valleys to the rivers and sea.

(mo chih ling),

It falls evenly (chün) by itself.

At the beginning of institution names come to be.

Once there are names,

One must know when to stop (chih chih).

One who knows when to stop does not become exhausted (pu tai).

Tao in the world is like

Valley streams flowing into rivers and seas.

Chapter 33

Addiss & Lombardo

Chapter 33

Raymond B. Blakney

Chapter 33

David Bullen

Chapter 33

David Hong Cheng

Chapter 33

Ellen Marie Chen

Knowing others is intelligent. Knowing yourself is enlightened.

Conquering others takes force.
Conquering yourself is true strength.

Knowing what is enough is wealth.

It is wisdom to know others;

It is enlightenment to know one's self.

The conqueror of men is powerful;

The master of himself is strong.

It is

With intellect, you have knowledge of others. Enlightened there is no self. With force you can master others. By yielding you master the Tao. In striving to accumulate wealth, you become poor.

He who understands others is intelligent;

He who knows himself is wise.

He who wins over others is persuasive;

He who conquers himself is strong.

He who

One who knows (chih) others is knowledgeable (chih);

One who knows (chih) the self is enlightened (ming).

One who overcomes others has physical might;

One who overcomes the self (tzu sheng) is strong (ch'iang).

Forging ahead shows inner resolve.

Hold your ground and you will last long. Die without perishing and your life will endure.

wealth to be content;

It is willful to force one's way on others.

Endurance is to keep one's place;

Long life it is to die and not perish.

In accepting what you have, you become rich. Do only what needs to be done and relax. If you accept death, you will live in eternity.

feels contented is rich;

He who acts forcefully is determined.

He who does not lose his center endures;

He who dies but is not forgotten enjoys long life.

One who knows contentment (chih tsu) is rich;

One who acts strongly (ch'iang) has will power (chih).

One who does not lose where one belongs lasts long;

One who dies without perishing (wang) has longevity.

Chapter 34

Addiss & Lombardo

Chapter 34

Raymond B. Blakney

Chapter 34

David Bullen

Chapter 34

David Hong Cheng

Chapter 34

Ellen Marie Chen

Great Tao overflows.
To the left To the right.

All beings owe their life to it And do not depart from it. It acts without a name.

O the great Way o'erflows

And spreads on every side!

All beings come from it;

No creature is denied.

But having called them forth,

It calls not one its own.

It feeds and clothes them all

And will not be their lord.

Without desire always,

It

The Tao flows constantly like a river. All things arise in it, but are not separate. It brings about the natural sequence of things, but makes no effort. It nourishes the whole universe, but claims no reward.

How the great Tao flows everywhere!

All things depend on it for life and it never turns away from them;

It completes the work successfully without seeking recognition;

It protects and nurtures all things without becoming their

The great Tao floods over,

To the left, to the right.

Ten thousand beings live by it,

And it does not reject them.

Work is accomplished (ch'eng), yet it has no name.

It clothes and nourishes ten thousand beings,
But does not lord

It clothes and nourishes all beings
But does not become their master.

Enduring without desires, It may be called slight.

All beings return to it, But it does not become their master. It may be called immense.

By not making itself great, It can do great things.

seems of slight import.

Yet, nonetheless, in this

Its greatness still appears:

When they return to it,

No creature meets a lord.

The Wise Man, therefore, while he is alive,

Will never make a show of being great:

And that is how his greatness is achieved.

Everything relies on it, but it does not rely on anything. All things come and go, but it alone is; that is its greatness. It has no desire to be great, so its greatness is complete.

master.

Always devoid of desire may be an insignificant accomplishment;

All things follow it without becoming their master has to be a great accomplishment.

Just because it has no desire to be great,

It can achieve greatness.

over them.

Always without desire,

It may be named the small;

Ten thousand beings return (kuei) to it,

Yet it does not lord over them,

It may be named the great.

Because it never considers itself great,

Therefore it can accomplish (ch'eng) its greatness.

Chapter 35

Addiss & Lombardo

Hold the great
elephant - The great
image - And the
world moves. Moves
without danger in
safety and peace.
Music and sweets
Make passing guests
pause.

Chapter 35

Raymond B. Blakney

Once grasp the great
Form without form,
And you roam where
you will
With no evil to fear,
Calm, peaceful, at
ease.
At music and viands
The

Chapter 35

David Bullen

The master being at
one with the Tao
doesn't feel
threatened when in
danger. Even if
surrounded by
misery he is perfectly
peaceful. People are
excited by the sound
of music or the taste
of food.

Chapter 35

David Hong Cheng

Whoever has a firm
hold on the big form,
The entire world will
follow him.
They will experience
no harm,
But security, peace
and comfort.
Having

Chapter 35

Ellen Marie Chen

Hold aloft the Great
Image (hsiang),
The whole world will
go to it.
Going to it, they will
meet with no harm,
Only safety, peace,
and contentment (an
p'ing t'ai).
When music and
dainty dishes are
offered,
The passers-by stop.

But the Tao emerges
Flavourless and
bland. Look - you
won't see it. Listen -
You won't hear it.
Use it - You will
never use it up.

wayfarer stops.
But the Way, when
declared,
Seems thin and so
flavorless!
It is nothing to look
at
And nothing to hear;
But used, it will
prove
Inexhaustible.

But they find words
which try to point out
the Tao flavourless.
If you try to look for
it, it cannot be seen.
If you try to listen for
it, it cannot be heard.
Experience it, and it
never ceases.

food and music,
Even passers-by stop.
Talking about Tao is
tasteless and plain.
And it is:
Invisible by looking;
Inaudible by
listening and
Inexhaustible by
using.

Tao, when it is
uttered by the mouth,
Is so bland it has no
flavor.
When looked at, it is
not enough to be
seen.
When listened to, it
is not enough to be
heard,
When used (yung), it
is inexhaustible.

Chapter 36

Addiss & Lombardo

Chapter 36

Raymond B. Blakney

Chapter 36

David Bullen

Chapter 36

David Hong Cheng

Chapter 36

Ellen Marie Chen

To collect, first scatter. To Weaken, first strengthen. To abolish, first establish. To conclude, first initiate.

This is called subtle illumination.

What is to be shrunken

Is first stretched out;

What is to be weakened

Is first made strong;

What will be thrown over

Is first raised up;

What will be withdrawn

Is first

For something to expand, first it must shrink. To strengthen something, first it must be weakened. To raise something, first it must be lowered. To receive something, first you must give.

In order to contract it, first allow it to expand.

In order to weaken it, first allow it to strengthen;

In order to eliminate it, first allow it to grow;

In order to take away from it,

What is to be reduced,

Must first be expanded.

What is to be weakened,

Must first be made strong (ch'iang).

What is to be abolished,

Must first be established.

What is to be taken away,

Must

Soft and weak overcome stiff and strong.

Fish cannot escape the deep pool. A country's sharpest weapons Cannot be displayed.

bestowed.

This indeed is

Subtle Light;

The gentle way

Will overcome

The hard and strong.

As fish should not

Get out of pools,

The realm's edged tools

Should not be shown

To anybody.

This subtlety can be seen in all matters. The soft overcomes the hard. The subtle penetrates the obvious. Keep your inner development a secret, and the results will be clear.

first allow it to receive.

These are called common sense which includes:

The soft and weak overcome the hard and strong;

A fish should not leave deep water;

State's sharp weapons should not be shown to others.

first be given.

This is called the subtle illumination (wei ming).

The soft and weak overcome the hard and strong.

Fish must not leave the stream.

Sharp weapons (ch'i) of a state,

Must not be displayed.

Chapter 37

Addiss & Lombardo

Chapter 37

Raymond B. Blakney

Chapter 37

David Bullen

Chapter 37

David Hong Cheng

Chapter 37

Ellen Marie Chen

Tao endures without
a name, Yet nothing
is left undone.

If kings and lords
could possess it, All
beings would
transform
themselves.

The Way is always
still, at rest,

And yet does
everything that's
done.

If then the king and
nobles could

Retain its potency for
good,

The creatures all
would be
transformed.

But if, the change
once made in

The Tao never does
anything, yet there is
nothing it doesn't do.
If a father instills this
virtue into his being,
the children will be
transformed by
themselves, in
accordance with their
nature.

Tao forever takes no
action but nothing is
left undone.

If barons and kings
were able to keep
faith in it,

All things will
transform
spontaneously on
their own.

Should selfish
desires arise anew,

I shall

Tao everlasting
(ch'ang) does not act
(wu wei),

And yet nothing is
not done (erh wu pu
wei).

If kings and barons
can abide by (shou)
it,

The ten thousand
things will transform
by themselves (tzu
hua).

If in transforming

Transformed, they
desire to create; I
quiet them through
nameless simplicity.
Then there is no
desire.

No desire is serenity,
An the world settles
of itself.

them,

They still inclined to
do their work,

I should restrain
them then

By means of that
unique

Original simplicity

Found in the Virgin
Block,

Which brings
disinterest,

With stillness in its
train,

And so, an ordered
world.

Following their
nature, their
contentment is total
and no desires would
arise. When no desire
arises, bliss and
tranquility abide.

counter them with
natural goodness yet
unnamed.

What the unnamed
natural goodness
brings,

Is but the riddance of
selfish desires.

Riddance of selfish
desires will bring
forth tranquility,

Then peace would
naturally prevail in
the world.

desire (yü) is
aroused,

I shall suppress it by
the nameless
uncarved wood (p'u).

With the nameless
uncarved wood,

There shall be no
desire (wu yü).

Without desire there
is thus quietude
(ching).

The world shall be
self-ordered (tzu
ting).

High Te? No Te!
That's what Te is.
Low Te doesn't lack
Te; That's what Te is
not.

Those highest in Te
take no action And
don't need to act.
Tose lowest in Te
take action And do
need to act.

Those highest in
benevolence take
action But don't need
to act. Those highest
in righteousness take
action And do need
to act.

Those highest in
propriety take action
And if people don't
reciprocate Roll up
their sleeves and
throw them —

A man of highest virtue
Will not display it as his
own;
His virtue then is real.
Low virtue makes one miss
no chance
To show his virtue off;
His virtue then is naught.
High virtue is at rest;
It knows no need to act.
Low virtue is a busyness
Pretending to
accomplishment.
Compassion at its best
Consists in honest deeds;
Morality at best
Is something done,
aforethought;
High etiquette, when acted
out
Without response from
others,

The master needs no
satisfaction, so his
acts are always pure.
An ordinary man
demands satisfaction,
so his acts are always
tainted. The master is
not a doer, so nothing
is to be done. An
ordinary man is a
doer, so many things
need doing. A man
who tries to do the
right thing creates
more problems. A
man who tries to do
the moral thing will
use force. If people
can't act naturally,
they may try to be
good.

The people of high virtue
show no appearance of
virtue, they are thus
virtuous;
The people of low virtue
lose no appearance of
virtue, they are thus not
virtuous.
The people of high virtue
take no action, but with no
ulterior motive;
The people of low virtue
take actions and with
ulterior motive.
The people of high
humanity take actions, but
with no ulterior motive.
The people of high justice
take actions and with
ulterior motives.
The people of high
propriety take actions, upon
receiving no response, they
extend their

A person of high te is not te,
Therefore such a person has
te;
A person of low te does not
lose (shih) te,
Therefore such a person has
no te.
A person of high te does not
act (wei),
For such a person has no
cause for action;
A person of low te acts,
For such a person has cause
for action.
A person of high jen
(humanity) acts,
Yet such a person has no
cause for action;
A person of high i
(righteousness) acts,
For such a person has cause
for action.
A person of high li
(propriety) acts,
Yet finding no response,
Proceeds to bare the

out.
Therefore Lose Tao
And Te follows. Lose
Te and benevolence
follows. Lose
benevolence And
righteousness
follows. Lose
righteousness and
propriety follows.
Propriety dilutes
loyalty and sincerity:
Confusion begins.
Foreknowledge
glorifies the Tao:
Stupidity sets in.
And so the ideal
person dwells In
substance, not
dilution, In reality,
not glory, Accepts
one, rejects the other.

And make them do their
duty!
Truly, once the Way is lost,
There comes then virtue;
Virtue lost, comes then
compassion;
After that morality;
And when that's lost, there's
etiquette,
The husk of all good faith,
The rising point of anarchy.
Foreknowledge is, they say,
The Doctrine come to
flower;
But better yet, it is
The starting point of
silliness.
So once full-grown, a man
will take
The meat and not the husk,
The fruit and not the
flower.
Rejecting one, he takes the
other.

If they can't be good,
they may try to be
moral. If they can't
be moral, they may
try to be fair. If they
can't be fair they will
conform. Conformity
appears to be
politeness and
sincerity, but is really
the realm of
confusion and folly.
The master dwells in
the depths of reality.
He considers the use
of occult powers as
foolishness. The
miracle is the flower.
The Tao is the fruit.
Dwell in the fruit, for
nourishment can only
be found there.

arms to fight.
Therefore:
When Tao is lost, one is left
with virtue;
When virtue is lost, one is
left with humanity;
When humanity is lost, one
is left with justice;
When justice is lost, one is
left with propriety.
But propriety requires only
superficial loyalty and trust,
and is the cause for discords
and violence.
These so-called prophecies
represent the superficial
Tao, and is the beginning of
ignorance.
Therefore a person of
substance:
Prefers depth to
shallowness, and
Chooses substance over
appearance.
And he takes this and
discards the other.

arms and throw a rope.
Therefore when Tao is lost
(shih), then there is te.
When te is lost, then there is
jen (humanity).
When jen is lost, then there is
i (righteousness).
When i is lost, then there is li
(propriety).
As to li, it is the thin edge of
loyalty and faithfulness,
And the beginning of
disorder;
As to foreknowledge (ch'ien
shih), it is the flowering of
Tao,
And the beginning of
stupidity (yü).
Thus a great person, abiding
in the thick,
Does not dwell in the thin;
Abiding in the kernel,
Does not dwell in the flower.
Therefore such a person
leaves that and takes this.

Of old, these attained the One: Heaven attaining the One Became clear. Earth attaining the One Became stable. Spirits attaining the One Became sacred.

Valleys attaining the One Became bountiful. Myriad beings attaining the One Became fertile. Lords and kings attaining the One Purified the world.

If Heaven were not clear It might split. If Earth were not stable It might erupt. If spirits were not sacred They might fade.

If —

These things in ancient times received the One:

The sky obtained it and was clarified;

The earth received it and was settled firm;

The spirits got it and were energized;

The valleys had it, filled to overflow;

All things, as they partook it came alive;

The nobles and the king imbibed the One

In order that the realm might upright be;

Such things were then accomplished by the One.

Without its clarity the sky might break;

Except it were set firm, the earth might shake;

Without their energy the gods would pass;

Unless kept

The Tao is not separate from mind, body and spirit. But mind, body and spirit can separate from the Tao. A clear mind and you are as open as the sky. A healthy body and you are as vital as the earth. A free spirit and you are bound to nothing. A mind which is divided by thoughts lacks clarity.

Whichever has been endowed with the One:

Heaven becomes clear;

Earth becomes calm;

Spiritual beings become divine;

Valleys become full;

All things are striving;

Barons and kings are leaders of the world.

All these are due to the One. Otherwise:

Heaven would not be clear, and may disintegrate;

Earth would not be calm, and may quake;

Spiritual beings would not be divine, and may disappear;

Valleys would not be full, and may dry up;

All things would not be

Those of old that attain the One:

Heaven attains the One thus is clear,

Earth attains the One thus is peaceful,

Spirits attain the One thus are efficacious,

Valleys attain the One thus are replenished,

Ten thousand beings attain the One thus come to be,

Princes and barons attain the One thus are exalted in the world.

All because they attain the One.

Heaven, without that which renders it clear, might crack,

Earth, without that which renders it peaceful, might explode,

Spirits, without that which makes them efficacious, might

valleys were not bountiful They might wither.

If myriad beings were not fertile, They might perish. If rulers and lords were not noble, They might stumble.

Therefore, Noble has humble as its root, High has low as its foundation.

Rulers and lords call themselves Poor and lonely orphans. Isn't this using humility as a root?

They use many carriages But have no carriage;.

full, the valleys might go dry;

Except for life, all things would pass away;

Unless the One did lift and hold them high,

The nobles and the king might trip and fall.

The humble folk support the mighty ones;

They are base on which the highest rest.

The nobles and the king speak of themselves

As "orphans," "desolate" and "needy ones."

Does this not indicate that they depend

Upon the lowly people for support?

Truly a cart is more than the sum of its parts.

Better to rumble like rocks

Than to tinkle like jade.

A body which indulges the senses becomes ill. A spirit which is chained to the world will break. The master serves his mind, body and spirit all they require, and asks not a thing in return. With no will of his own, the Tao leads him to an unknown destination. How could this not be the greatest journey of man?

thriving, and may perish;

Barons and kings would not be noble and high, and may topple.

Therefore:

Humility is the basis for nobleness; and

Lowness the foundation for highness.

That is why barons and kings call themselves orphans, widowers and destitute beings.

Does it not prove humility being the basis for nobleness? Is it not?

Thus:

Strive for too many honours ends up with no honour.

Do not wish to be a shining jade, just be an ordinary rock.

cease,

Valleys, without that which replenishes them, might become empty,

Ten thousand beings, without that which sustains them in existence, might become extinct,

Barons and kings, without that which exalts them to high positions, might be toppled.

Therefore the exalted is rooted in the humble,

The high has the low for foundation.

Therefore barons and kings call themselves orphaned, widowed and unworthy.

Is this not taking the humble for one's root?

Is it not?

Therefore the most famous has no fame.

Do not tinkle like jade,

Or chime like stones!

Chapter 40

Addiss & Lombardo

Chapter 40

Raymond B. Blakney

Chapter 40

David Bullen

Chapter 40

David Hong Cheng

Chapter 40

Ellen Marie Chen

Reversal is Tao's movement. Yielding is Tao's practice.

The movement of the Way is a return;
In weakness lies its major usefulness.
From

All things return to the Tao. The Tao yields to receive them all.

Tao moves in cycles.
Tao uses the soft and weak to reveal the truth.
All things

Returning (fan) is the movement (tung) of Tao.
Weak (jo) is the functioning (yung) of Tao.

All things originate from being. Being originates from non-being.

What-is all the world of things was born
But What-is sprang in turn from
What-is-not.

Everything appears to be something.
Something arises out of nothing.

in the world are born from being, and
Being (the named) is born from non-being (the unnamed).

Ten thousand things under heaven are born of being (yu).
Being is born of non-being (wu).

Chapter 41

Addiss & Lombardo

The great scholar
hearing the Tao Tries
to practice it. The
middling scholar
hearing the Tao,
Sometimes has it,
sometimes not.

The lesser scholar
hearing the Tao Has
a good laugh.
Without that laughter
It wouldn't be Tao.

Therefore these
sayings: The bright
road seems dark, The
road forward sees to
retreat, The level
road seems

Chapter 41

Raymond B. Blakney

On hearing of the Way,
the best of men
Will earnestly explore its
length.

The mediocre person
learns of it

And takes it up and sets
it down.

But vulgar people, when
they hear the news,

Will laugh out loud, and
if they did not laugh,

It would not be the Way.

And so there is a
proverb:

"When going looks like
coming back,

The clearest road is

mighty —

dar —

k —

. —

Chapter 41

David Bullen

One, who upon
hearing of the Tao is
immediately
transformed, is
superior. One, who
upon hearing of the
Tao, half doubts it, is
average. One, who
upon hearing of the
Tao laughs at it, is
inferior. If fools
didn't scoff at it, it
wouldn't be great.

Chapter 41

David Hong Cheng

When Tao is heard by
a man of high
intellect,

He practices it with
diligence.

When Tao is heard by
a man of average
intellect,

He follows it
half-heartedly.

When Tao is heard by
a man of no intellect,

He will have a hearty
laugh at it.

And it would not be
Tao without being
laughed at.

Thus there is the
accepted saying:

The bright way
appears dark; the
progressive

Chapter 41

Ellen Marie Chen

When a superior person
(shan shih) hears Tao,
He diligently practices
it.

When a middling person
(chung shih) hears Tao,

He hears it, he doesn't
hear it.

When the inferior person
(hsia shih) hears Tao, he
roars.

If Tao were not laughed
at,

It would not be Tao.

Therefore, established
sayings (chien yen) have
it this way:

"The illuminating (ming)
Tao appears (jo) dark,

The advancing Tao
appears retreating,

The level Tao appears

rough.

Great Te seems
hollow. Great purity
seems sullied.
Pervasive Te sees
deficient. Established
Te seems furtive.
Simple truths seem to
change. The great
square has no
corners. The great
vessel is finished
late. The great sound
is scarcely voiced.
The great image has
no form.

Tao hides, no name.
Yet Tao alone gets
things done.

Today, the Way that's
plain looks rough,

And lofty virtue like a
chasm;

The purest innocence
like shame,

The broadest power not
enough,

Established goodness
knavery,

Substantial worth like
shifting tides.

Great space has no
corners;

Great powers come late;

Great music is soft
sound;

The great Form no
shape.

The Way is obscure and
unnamed;

It is a skilled investor,
nonetheless,

Thus it is said: Light
seems to arise out of
darkness. To go
forward appears to be
going in reverse. To
be simple seems
complicated. Real
compassion seems
harsh. Real strength
seems weak. The
unchanged seems to
change. Great love
seems indifferent.
The master seems
like a fool. The Tao
is nothing, but
through it everything
is.

way, regressive; and
the smooth way,
uneven.

The high virtue
appears hollow; the
purest white, tinted;
the far-reaching
virtue, inadequate; the
firm virtue,

lax; and the real
quality, wanting.

The greatest square
appears cornerless; the
great talent, the last to
be recognized; the
great music, devoid of

appealing sound; and
the great image,
formless.

Tao is hidden and
nameless,

knotty (lei).

High (shan) te appears
like a valley,

Great whiteness (po)
appears spotted (ju),

Expansive te appears
insufficient,

Well-established te
appears weak,

The genuine in
substance appears
hollow.

Great (ta) square has no
corners,

Great vessel (ch'i) is late
in completion,

Great voice (yin) has
hardly (hsi) any sound,

Great image is formless,

Tao is hidden and
without name."

Yet it is Tao alone,

Chapter 42

Addiss & Lombardo

Chapter 42

Raymond B. Blakney

Chapter 42

David Bullen

Chapter 42

David Hong Cheng

Chapter 42

Ellen Marie Chen

Tao engenders One,
One engenders Two,
Two engenders
Three, Three
engenders the ten
thousand things.

The ten thousand
things carry shade
And embrace
sunlight. Shade and
sunlight, yin and
yang, Breath
blending into
harmony.

Humans hate To be
alone, poor, and
hungry.

The Way begot one,
And the one, two;
Then the two begot
three

And three, all else.

All things bear the
shade on their backs
And the sun in their
arms;

By the blending of
breath

From the sun and the
shade,

Equilibrium comes to
the world.

Orphaned, or needy,
or desolate, these

Are conditions

The Tao gave birth to
the universe. The
universe gave birth to
the earth. The earth
gave birth to man.
Man gave birth to
everything.
Everything is
experience, but
receives a name.

Tao created the One;
The One produced
the Two;

The two produced
the Three;

And the Three
produced all things.

All things carry the
Yin (female) and
embrace the Yang
(male),

Harmony is achieved
through interaction
of these prime
energies.

People hate to be
orphans, widowers,

Tao gives birth to
one,

One gives birth to
two,

Two gives birth to
three,

Three gives birth to
ten thousand beings.

Ten thousand beings
carry yin on their
backs and embrace
yang in their front,

Blending these two
vital breaths (ch'i) to
attain harmony (ho).

What people hate
most,

Are to be orphaned,
widowed and

Yet kings and princes
Use these words as
titles.

We gain by losing,
Lose by gaining.

What others teach, I
also teach: "A violent
man does not die a
natural death. This is
the basis of my
teaching.

much feared and
disliked;

Yet in public address,
the king

And the nobles
account themselves
thus.

So a loss sometimes
benefits one

Or a benefit proves to
be loss.

What others have
taught

I also shall teach:

If a violent man does
not come

To a violent death,

I shall choose him to
teach me.

There is total
harmony when name
and experience
combine. An
ordinary man seeks a
name in the eyes of
others, but at their
expense. The master
experiences for
himself. A violent
man will not enjoy a
natural death.

or being destitute,

Yet kings and barons
call themselves by
these terms.

Thus:

One my gain by
losing first, and

One my lose by
gaining first.

What people teach I
can also teach.

"A violent person
would not die a
natural death,"

Shall be my first
lesson.

unworthy.

Yet kings and dukes
call themselves by
these.

Thus things are either
decreased so as to be
increased,

Or increased (i) so as
to be decreased (sun).

What others teach,
I also teach:

"The strong and
violent (ch'iang
liang) do not die a
natural death."

This I shall hold as
the father (fu) of my
teaching.

Chapter 43

Addiss & Lombardo

Chapter 43

Raymond B. Blakney

Chapter 43

David Bullen

Chapter 43

David Hong Cheng

Chapter 43

Ellen Marie Chen

The softest thing in the world rides roughshod over the strongest. No-thing enters no-space.

The softest of stuff in the world
Penetrates quickly the hardest;
Insubstantial, it enters
Where no room is.
By this I know the benefit

The softest overcomes the hardest, by yielding. Emptiness can enter where there is no space.

The softest thing in the world is galloping inside of the hardest;
The invisible substance is entering media having no space.
I therefore

The softest (chih jou) in the world,
Gallops (ch'ih ch'eng) in the hardest (chih chien) in the world.
That which is not penetrates that which has no crevice (wu

This teaches me the benefits of no-action.
Teaching without words Benefit without action - Few in this world can attain this.

Of something done by quiet being;
In all the world but few can know
Accomplishment apart from work,
Instruction when no words are used.

The value of non-action is in acting naturally. Therefore the master teaches of what is beyond words. And his acts carry no expectations.

learn the benefits of taking no action.
Lessons without words and the value of taking no action,
There are few rivals in the world.

yu ju wu chien).
I thereby know the benefit of no-action (wu-wei).
The teaching without words,
The benefit of no-action,
Hardly anything in the world can compare with them.

Chapter 44

Addiss & Lombardo

Chapter 44

Raymond B. Blakney

Chapter 44

David Bullen

Chapter 44

David Hong Cheng

Chapter 44

Ellen Marie Chen

Name or body: which is closer? Body or possessions: which means more? Gain or loss: Which one hurts?

Extreme love exacts a great price.

Which is dearer, fame or self?

Which is worth more, man or pelf?

Which would hurt more, gain or loss?

The mean man pays

Is fame more important than living? Is money more important than happiness? What do you consider success or failure?

Fame or life, which is more precious?

Life or wealth, which is more important?

Gain or loss, which is more harmful?

An obsession for possession is doomed to be costly;

An

Your name and your body (shen), which is dearer?

Your body and material goods, which is more abundant?

Gain and loss, which is illness?

Therefore in excessive love one necessarily goes to great

Many possessions entail a heavy loss.

Know what is enough - Abuse nothing. Know when to stop - Harm nothing. This is how to last for a long time.

the highest price;

The hoarder takes the greatest loss;

A man content is never shamed,

And self-restrained, is not in danger:

He will live forever.

Fame fulfils the lives of others. Happiness cannot be bought. Living is a celebration of the way things are. Happiness is wanting no more.

excessive hoarding for profits is sure to incur heavy losses.

He who is contented loses no honour;

He who knows when to stop encounters no danger;

He can thus long endure.

expenses,

In hoarding much one necessarily loses heavily.

Knowing contentment (chih tsu) one does not suffer disgrace,

Knowing when to stop one does not become exhausted (tai).

This way one may last long.

Chapter 45

Addiss & Lombardo

Chapter 45

Raymond B. Blakney

Chapter 45

David Bullen

Chapter 45

David Hong Cheng

Chapter 45

Ellen Marie Chen

Great accomplishment seems unfinished But its use is continuous. Great fullness seems empty But in use is inexhaustible.

Great straightness seems

Most perfect, yet it seems

Imperfect, incomplete:

Its use is not impaired.

Filled up, and yet it seems

Poured out, an empty void:

It never will run dry.

The straightest, yet it seems

To deviate,

Although things appear imperfect, herein lies their perfection. Fullness appears empty, herein lies its fullness. That which is straight appears bent.

A perfect tool appears defective, but, it shows no impairment in operation.

A great abundance appears empty, but, it is inexhaustible in consumption.

A truly straight edge appears

Great perfection appears lacking (ch'üeh),

Its use is unending.

Great fullness appears empty,

Its use is inexhaustible.

Great straightness appears bent,

Great ingenuity (ch'iao) appears crude,

Great eloquence (pien)

bent, Great skill seems clumsy, Great eloquence seems mute.

Exertion overcomes cold. Calm overcomes heat. Pure calm is the norm under heaven.

to bend;

The highest skill and yet

It looks like clumsiness.

The utmost eloquence,

It sounds like stammering.

As movement overcomes

The cold, and stillness, heat,

The Wise Man, pure and still,

Will rectify the world.

The wise appear foolish. The talented appear unskilled. That which is still appears to move. By not moving, the master can move into any situation.

crooked,

A great cleverness appears clumsy,

A great orator appears tight tongued.

Vigorous exercise overcomes cold;

Calm quietude overcomes heat.

Clear heads and calm minds can right the world.

appears inarticulate.

When agitation (tsao) wins (sheng), the cold arrives,

When tranquillity (ching) wins (sheng), the hot arrives.

Clear and tranquil the world is in the right mode (cheng).

Chapter 46

Addiss & Lombardo

Chapter 46

Raymond B. Blakney

Chapter 46

David Bullen

Chapter 46

David Hong Cheng

Chapter 46

Ellen Marie Chen

With Tao under
heaven Stray horses
fertilize the fields.
Without Tao under
heaven Warhorses
are bred at the
frontier.

There is no greater
calamity Than not
knowing what is
enough.

When the Way rules
the world,
Coach horses fertilize
the fields;
When the Way does
not rule,
War horses breed in
the parks.
No sin can exceed
Incitement

With the Tao,
everything serves a
natural creative
function. With man,
weapons are made to
destroy.

When Tao prevails in
the world,
Horses walk in the
field to fertilize.
When Tao is missing
in the world,
Military horses give
births in the suburbs.
No guilt is

When the world
practices Tao,
Fast horses are used
for their dung.
When the world does
not practice Tao,
War horses give birth
at the borders.
Among offenses
(tsui), none is greater
than having what

There is no greater
fault Than desire for
success.

Therefore, Knowing
that enough is
enough Is always
Enough.

to envy;
No calamity's worse
Than to be
discontented,
Nor is there an omen
More dreadful than
coveting.
But once be
contented,
And truly you'll
always be so.

Desire creates fear
and violence.
Without desire there
is no fear. Free from
fear you are eternal.

greater than
insatiable desires;
No misfortune is
greater than mindless
discontent;
No sin is greater than
uncontrollable greed.
Therefore,
He who knows the
contentment of being
contented,
Will always be
contented.

is desirable.
Among calamities
(huo), none is greater
than not knowing
contentment.
Among blames
(chiu), none is
greater than the
desire for gain.
Therefore the
contentment that
comes from knowing
contentment
Is a long lasting
contentment.

Chapter 47

Addiss & Lombardo

Chapter 47

Raymond B. Blakney

Chapter 47

David Bullen

Chapter 47

David Hong Cheng

Chapter 47

Ellen Marie Chen

Without going out
the door, Know the
world. Without
peeping through the
window, See
heaven's Tao.

The world may be
known
Without leaving the
house;
The Way may be
seen
Apart from the
windows.
The further

You cannot go
anywhere to
experience the Tao. It
can only be
experienced here.
The more knowledge
you have, the less
you know.

Without stepping out
of the door,
He knows what the
world is like.
Without looking out
of the window,
He understands the
way of

Without stepping
(ts'u) out the door,
Know (chih) the
world.
Without looking out
the window,
See (chien) the Tao
of Heaven.
The farther one

The further you
travel, The less you
know.
This is why the Sage
Knows without
budging, Identifies
without looking,
Does without trying.

you go,
The less you will
know.
Accordingly, the
Wise Man
Knows without
going,
Sees without seeing,
Does without doing.

The master knows
without knowledge,
and sees without
eyes. Without
thinking of success is
his eternal success.

Heaven.
The farther he
travels,
The less he learns.
So the Sage:
Knows without
traveling;
Understands
situations without
seeing, and
Succeeds without
taking action.

comes out,
The less one knows.
Therefore the sage
knows (chih) without
travelling,
Names (ming) things
without seeing
(chien) them,
Accomplishes
(cheng) without work
(wei).

Chapter 48

Addiss & Lombardo

Chapter 48

Raymond B. Blakney

Chapter 48

David Bullen

Chapter 48

David Hong Cheng

Chapter 48

Ellen Marie Chen

Pursue knowledge,
gain daily. Pursue
Tao, lose daily. Lose
and again lose,
Arrive at non-doing.
Non-doing - and

The student learns by
daily increment.
The Way is gained
by daily loss,
Loss upon loss until
At last comes rest.
By letting go, it

You learn something
everyday through
knowledge. You
unlearn something
everyday
experiencing the Tao.
Unlearn more and
more until you know.

Pursuing learning,
one needs to learn
more every day.
Practicing Tao, one
needs to do less
every day.
Less and even less,
one reaches a state of
taking

To pursue (wei)
learning one
increases daily.
To pursue (wei) Tao
one decreases daily.
To decrease and
again to decrease,
Until one arrives at
not doing (wu-wei).
Not

nothing not done.
Take the entire world
as nothing. Make the
least effort, And the
world escapes you.

all gets done;
The world is won by
those who let it go!
But when you try and
try,
The world is then
beyond the winning.

Then there is no
doer, thus nothing to
do. Doing nothing,
let things take their
natural course. Try to
do something and
you will miss.

no action.
Taking no action but
nothing is left
undone.
Taking over an
empire must always
be a nonevent.
If eventful, it is
unworthy of taking
over the empire.

doing (wu-wei) and
yet nothing is not
done.
Always take the
empire when there
are no businesses.
If there are
businesses,
It is not worthwhile
to take the empire.

Chapter 49

Addiss & Lombardo

Chapter 49

Raymond B. Blakney

Chapter 49

David Bullen

Chapter 49

David Hong Cheng

Chapter 49

Ellen Marie Chen

The Sage has no set heart. Ordinary people's hearts Become the Sage's heart.

People who are good I treat well. People who are not good I also treat well: Te as goodness.

Trustworthy people I trust.

The Wise Man's mind is free

But tuned to people's need:

"Alike to be good and bad

I must be good,

For Virtue is goodness.

To honest folk

And those dishonest ones

Alike, I proffer faith,

The master has no fixed ideas, but accepts whatever comes his way. His is an unbending trust in existence, so he treats all the same. He trusts that a good man is doing the right thing.

A wise ruler has no preconceived ideas,

He adopts the people's ideas as his own.

I treat good people with goodness,

I treat bad people also with goodness.

This is the virtue of goodness.

I deal with honest people with honesty,

I

The sage has no set mind (ch'ang hsin),

He takes the mind of the people as his mind.

The good (shan) I am good to them,

The not good I am also good to them.

This is the goodness of nature (te).

The trustworthy

Untrustworthy people I also trust. Te as trust.

Sages create harmony under heaven Blending their hearts with the world. Ordinary people fix their eyes and ears upon them, But Sages become the world's children.

For Virtue is faithful."

The Wise Man, when abroad,

Impartial to the world,

Does not divide or judge.

But people everywhere

Mark well his ears and eyes;

For wise men hear and see

As little children do.

He also trusts that a bad man is doing the right thing. He keeps his trust a secret, knowing others cannot understand. He appears to be like a child.

deal with dishonest people also with honesty.

This is the virtue of honesty.

For the benefit of the world, the wise ruler harmonizes all ideas.

(The people pay attention to him through ears and eyes,)

And he treats them all like his children.

(hsin) I trust them,

The not trustworthy I also trust them.

This is the trust of nature (te).

The sage in the world,

Mixes (hun) the minds (hsin) of all.

The people lift up their eyes and ears,

The sage treats them all like children.

Chapter 50

Addiss & Lombardo

Chapter 50

Raymond B. Blakney

Chapter 50

David Bullen

Chapter 50

David Hong Cheng

Chapter 50

Ellen Marie Chen

Emerge into life,
enter death,

Life is only the
thirteen body parts.
Death is only the
thirteen body parts.
Human life, moving
towards death, Is the
same thirteen. Why is
this? Because life
gives life to
substance.

You have heard of
people Good at
holding on to life.

On leaving life, to
enter death:

Thirteen members
form a living body;
A corpse has thirteen,
too:

Thirteen spots by
which a man may
pass

From life to death.
Why so?

Because his way of
life

Is much too gross.

As I have heard, the
man who knows

On land how best to

Ordinary people
revolve in the misery
of birth and death.
The master is free
from birth and death.
A person is not born
of existence, but born
of societal
conditioning.
Ordinary people are
like water which
fears the death of
freezing.

From birth to death,
Three out of ten
follow the path of
life;
Three out of ten
follow the path of
death; also

Three out of ten who
follow the path of life
may move into path
of death.

Why is that? Because
they over strive in
their lives.

I heard that he who

From coming out to
life to going back to
death:

Those companions
(t'u) of life,
They are one-third
(shih-yu-san);

Those companions of
death,
They are one-third;

Those living but
moving toward the
place of death,
They are also
one-third.

Why?

Because of the
intense (hou)
life-producing
activity.

Walking overland
they don't avoid
Rhinos and tigers. In
battle they don't arm
themselves.

The rhino's horn find
nothing to gore; The
tiger's claws find
nothing to flay,
Weapons find
nothing to pierce.
Why is this? They
have no mortal spot.

be at peace

Will never meet a
tiger or a buffalo;
In battle, weapons do
not touch his skin.

There is no place the
tiger's claws can grip;
Or with his horn, the
buffalo can jab;

Or where the soldier
can insert his sword.

Why so? In him there
is no place of death.

The master is like
H2O and welcomes
the movement of one
state to another as the
natural course of
things. Because he
accepts death, he is
always safe. Wild
beasts or weapons
cannot harm him.

excels in
self-preservation:

Meets no tiger or
rhinoceros while
walking on land;

Escapes harm while
fighting in wars.

And he encounters:

No rhinoceros
butting its horn
against him;

No tiger exerting its
claws against him;

No soldier thrusting
his knife against him.

Why is this so?

Because he is not on
the path of death.

to nourish life,
On land meets no
tigers or wild
buffaloes,

In battle needs to
wear no armors or
weapons,

A wild buffalo has
nowhere to butt its
horns,

A tiger has nowhere
to sink its claws,

A weapon has
nowhere to enter its
blade.

Why?

Because such a one
has no place of death.

Tao bears them Te nurses them Events form them Energy completes them. Therefore the ten thousand beings Honour Tao and respect Te. Tao is honoured Te is respected Because they do not give orders But endure in their own nature.

The Way brings forth,
Its virtue fosters them,
With matter they take shape,
And circumstance perfects them all:
That is why all things Do honor the Way
And venerate its power.
The exaltation of the Way,
The veneration of its power,
Come not by fate or decree;
But always just because

For every being, the Tao is. Conscious existence comes naturally. Physical appearance is determined by circumstances. Therefore, the Tao is honoured by all without effort. All are born of it, and it provides their livelihood.

Tao creates all things,
Virtue nurtures them.
Matter gives them forms, and
Environment allows them to succeed.
Thus all things honour Tao and value Virtue.
Tao being honoured and Virtue being valued,
They always occurred naturally without being dictated by anyone.
Thus:
Tao creates

Tao gives birth,
Te rears (hsü),
Things (wu) shape,
Circumstances (shih) complete.
Therefore the ten thousand things,
None do not respect Tao and treasure te.
Tao is respected,
Te is treasured,
Not by decree (ming),
But by spontaneity

Therefore, Tao bears them and Te nurses them, Rears them, Raises them, Shelters them, Nurtures them, Supports them, Protects them.

Bears them without owning them, Helps them without coddling them, Rears them without ruling them. This is called original Te.

is so.
So when the Way brings forth,
Its power fosters all:
They grow, are reared,
And fed and housed until
They come to ripe maturity.
You shall give life to things
But never possess them;
Your work shall depend on none;
You shall be chief but never lord.
This describes the mystic power.

It is the safe haven of life and the destination of death. It produces everything, but possesses nothing. Through it all opportunities arise, but it isn't involved. Its virtue is total, and its function is mysterious.

all thing.
Virtue nurtures them:
They grow and develop;
Bear fruits and mature; and
Are cared for and protected.
To create, but not to possess;
To care for, but not to control;
To lead, but not to subjugate.
This is called the profound virtue.

(tzu-jan).
Therefore Tao gives birth,
Te keeps, grows, nurtures, matures, ripens, covers and buries.
To give birth without possession,
To act (wei) without holding on to,
To grow (chang) without lording over,
This is called the dark te.

Chapter 52

Addiss & Lombardo

Chapter 52

Raymond B. Blakney

Chapter 52

David Bullen

Chapter 52

David Hong Cheng

Chapter 52

Ellen Marie Chen

The world has a source: the world's mother. Once you have the mother, You know the children.

Once you know the children, Return to the mother. Your body dies. There is no danger.

Block the passage, Bolt the gate: No strain Until your

It began with a matrix:

The world had a mother

Whose sons can be known

As ever, by her.

But if you know them,

You'll keep close to her

As long as you live

And suffer no harm.

Stop up your senses;

Close up your doors;

Be not exhausted

As long as you live.

Open your

Everything begins with the Tao and ends with the Tao. To know it retrace the steps of your life. When you reach back to the beginning, the Tao lies herein. Then you will realise there is no death.

The world had its beginning,

Which is known as the mother of the world.

Once the mother is known, her sons may be understood.

Once the sons are understood, still keep to the mother.

Then you will avoid mistakes all your life.

Close your apertures, shut your doors,

You will live a

The world (t'ien hsia) has an origin (shih),

Which is the world's (t'ien hsia) mother (mu).

Having reached the mother,

(We) know her child.

Having known the child,

Return and abide by its mother.

(In this way) one loses the body without becoming exhausted.

Stop the apertures (tui),

Close the doors,

life ends.

Open the passage, Take charge of things No relief Until your life ends.

Seeing the small is called brightness Maintaining gentleness is called strength.

Use this brightness to return to brightness. Don't cling to your body's woes. Then you can learn endurance.

senses;

Be busier still:

To the end of your days

There's no help for you.

You are bright, it is said,

If you see what is small;

A store of small strengths

Makes you strong.

By the use of its light,

Make your eyes again bright

From evil to lead you away.

This is called "practicing constancy."

Without desire your heart is at peace. Without judgment your mind is clear. See who it is that sees. Witness thoughts come and go. Turn the light around and find its source. Practicing this leads to enlightenment.

life without toil;

Open your apertures, meddle in distractions,

You will live a life beyond salvation.

Capable of seeing details is called clear vision;

Capable of yielding is called strength.

Using the innate light, recover your clear vision.

Then you will not be exposed to hidden danger.

This is called following the nature.

(ch'in).

Open the apertures, Going about the affairs,

(In this way) one's whole life (shen) cannot be saved.

To see the small is called illumination (ming).

To abide by the soft is called strength.

Use the bright light (kuang),

But return to the dim light (ming),

Do not expose your life (shen) to perils,

Such is to follow (hsi) the everlasting (ch'ang).

Chapter 53

Addiss & Lombardo

Having some
knowledge When
walking on the Great
Tao Only brings fear.

The great Tao is very
smooth, But people
like rough trails.

The government is
divided, Fields are
overgrown,
Granaries are empty,.

Chapter 53

Raymond B. Blakney

When I am walking
on the mighty Way,

Let me but know the
very least I may,

And I shall only fear
to leave the road.

The mighty Way is
easy underfoot,

But people still
prefer the little paths.

The royal court is
dignified, sedate,

While farmers' fields

Chapter 53

David Bullen

Freedom lies in the
Tao. Habits are
binding. There is
freedom in
moderation, and
bondage in excess.
When the wealthy
thrive at the expense
of others, is this not
theft?

Chapter 53

David Hong Cheng

Grant me the subtle
wisdom, that

I will follow the
broad way and be
fearful of straying
away.

The broad way is
flat, yet people still
indulge in shortcuts.

The palace is quite
splendid, but

The fields

Chapter 53

Ellen Marie Chen

If I have a little
(chieh-jan)
knowledge (chih),

To walk the great
path (Tao),

I shall fear this:

The great path (Tao)
is very flat and easy,

Yet others (jen) are
fond of bypaths.

The courts are very
neat,

The

But the nobles
clothes are gorgeous,
Their belts show off
swords, And they are
glutted with food and
drink. Personal
wealth is excessive.
This is called thieves'
endowment, But it is
not Tao.

are overgrown with
weeds;

The granaries are
empty and yet they

Are clad in
rich-embroidered
silken gowns.

They have sharp
swords suspended at
their sides;

With glutted wealth,
they gorge with food
and drink.

It is, the people say,

The boastfulness of
brigandage,

But surely not the
Way!

Is it not chaotic for a
rich man to flaunt his
money, when those
around have barely
enough? The
violence of excess
will end in disaster.

are quite desolate,
and

The granaries quite
empty.

(The rulers are)

Wearing beautiful
clothes,

Carrying sharp
swords,

Bored of feasts, and

Accumulating
excessive wealth and
treasures.

These are chieftains
of robbers, and

No behaving
according to Tao!

fields are very
weedy,

The granaries are
very empty.

Wearing
embroidered clothes,

Carrying sharp
swords,

Being surfeited with
foods and drinks.

To accumulate
wealth and treasures
in excess,

This is called robbery
and crime.

This is not to follow
Tao.

Chapter 54

Addiss & Lombardo

Chapter 54

Raymond B. Blakney

Chapter 54

David Bullen

Chapter 54

David Hong Cheng

Chapter 54

Ellen Marie Chen

Well planted, not uprooted. Well embraced, never lost. Descendants will continue The ancestral rituals.

Maintain oneself: Te becomes real.

Maintain the family: Te becomes abundant. Maintain the community: Te becomes extensive. Maintain the country: Te becomes public.

Set firm in the Way: none shall uproot you;

Cherish it well and none shall estrange you;

Your children's children faithful shall serve

Your forebears at the altar of your house.

Cultivate the Way yourself,

and your Virtue will be genuine.

Cultivate it in the home,

and its Virtue will overflow.

Cultivate it in the village,

and the village will endure.

If you are rooted in the Tao, you cannot be moved. If you hold to the Tao, time won't pass. You endlessly abide in the virtue of the Tao. When your life isn't separate from the Tao, your true self is.

A person who excels in building does not uproot;

A person who excels in embracing does not deviate;

And their descendants do not interrupt ancestral worship.\

Cultivate it in an individual, his virtue is genuine;

Cultivate it in a family, its virtue overflows;

Cultivate it in a community, its virtues multiply;

Cultivate it in a state, its virtue is abundant;

Cultivate it

One who is well established is not uprooted,

One who embraces firmly cannot be separated from,

Thus sons and grandsons shall perform sacrifices without interruptions.

In cultivating this in one's person,

The person's te becomes genuine;

In cultivating this in the family,

The family's te has more to spare (yü);

In cultivating this in the village,

The village's te grows strong;

In cultivating this in

Maintain the world: Te becomes omnipresent.

Therefore, Through self contemplate self, Through family contemplate family, Through community contemplate community, Through country contemplate country, Through world contemplate world.

How do I know the world? Like this!

will flourish.

Cultivate it in the world,

and Virtue will be universal.

Accordingly,

One will be judged by the Man of the Way;

Homes will be viewed through the Home of the Way;

And the Village shall measure the village;

And the Realm, for all realms, shall be standard;

And the World, to this world, shall be heaven.

How do I know the world is like this?

By this.

When your family isn't separate, they will flower. When the earth isn't separate, it is abundant. When the universe isn't separate, it is harmonious. From an atom, to the universe, there is no inside or outside. How do I know? By hearing with my eyes.

in the world, its virtue is universal.

Therefore, evaluate the virtue of:

An individual on the basis of the individual;

A family on the basis of the family;

A community o the basis of the community;

A state on the basis of the state;

The world on the basis of the world.

How do I know the situation of the world? By this.

the state,

The state's te becomes abundant;

In cultivating this in the world (t'ien hsia),

The world's te becomes universal.

Therefore observe (kuan) the person by the person,

Observe the family by the family,

Observe the village by the village,

Observe the state by the state,

Observe the world by the world.

How do I know such is the case in the world?

Through this.

Be filled with Te,
Like a baby: Wasps,
scorpions and vipers
Do not sting it.
Fierce tigers do not
stalk it. Birds of prey
do not attack it.
Bones weak, muscles
soft, But its grasp is
tight.
It does not yet know
Union of male and
female, But its sex is

Rich in virtue, like an
infant,
Noxious insects will
not sting him;
Wild beasts will not
attack his flesh
Nor birds of prey
sink claws in him.
His bones are soft,
his sinews weak,
His grip is
nonetheless robust;
Of sexual union
unaware,
His organs all
completely formed,
His vital force is at
its height.
He shouts all

The master's virtue is
to be like a newborn
child. Its connection
to the physical body
is weak, but its hold
on the Tao is strong.
Therefore it is free
from all physical
dangers. It hasn't
been conditioned, so
its energy is whole.

The abundant virtue of
a person,
May be compared to
that of an infant:
Poisonous insects do
not sting him,
Wild beats do not grab
him,
Birds of prey do not
claw him.
Though he has weak
bones and soft sinews,
his grip is firm.
Despite his ignorance
of union of male and
female, his organ is
often erect.
This demonstrates his
highest essence.
He cries all day
without

One who contains te
in fullness,
Is to be compared to
an infant.
Wasps, scorpions, and
snakes do not bite it,
Fierce beasts do not
attack it,
Birds of prey do not
pounce upon it.
Its bones weak, its
sinews tender,
But its grip is firm;
Knowing not the
union of the female
and male animals,
Yet its organ stirs.
Such is the perfection
of its life-force
(ching).
Crying all day, yet it
does

formed, Its vital
essence complete.
It can scream all day
and not get hoarse,
Its harmony is
complete. Knowing
harmony is called
endurance. Knowing
endurance is called
illumination.
Increasing life is
called fortune. Mind
controlling energy is
called power.
When beings prosper
and grow old, Call
them not-Tao.
Not-Tao soon ends.

day, does not get
hoarse:
His person is a
harmony.
Harmony
experienced is known
as constancy;
Constancy
experienced is called
enlightenment;
Exuberant vitality is
ominous, they say;
A bent for
vehemence is called
aggressiveness.
That things with age
decline in strength,
You well may say,
suits not the Way;
And not to suit the
Way is early death.

At one with nature, it
can scream all day
and never becomes
hoarse. If you follow
the natural flow there
will be no desire.
Without desire there
is no expectation.
Without expectation
there is no
disappointment.
Without
disappointment there
is serenity. In
serenity abides the
true breath, which is
the gateway to
enlightenment.

becoming hoarse.
This shows his utmost
harmony with Nature.
To know the harmony
with Nature is to
know the truth;
To know the truth is
enlightenment.
Over indulging in life
produces ill
consequences,
Ceding control of vital
energy to emotion
leads to violence.
Everything decays
after its prime.
These (over indulging,
ceding control to
emotion) would be
counter to Tao,

not get hoarse.
Such is the Perfection
of its harmony (ho).
To know harmony is
to know the
everlasting (ch'ang);
To know the
everlasting is to be
illuminated (ming).
To help life along is to
bring ill portend;
To use mind (hsin) to
direct the life breath
(ch'i) is called the
strong (ch'iang).
When things are
full-grown they
become old,
It is called not
following the Way
(Tao).

Chapter 56

Addiss & Lombardo

Chapter 56

Raymond B. Blakney

Chapter 56

David Bullen

Chapter 56

David Hong Cheng

Chapter 56

Ellen Marie Chen

Those who know
don't talk. Those who
talk don't know.

Block the passage
Bolt the gate Blunt
the sharp Untie the
knot Blend with the
light Become one
with the dust - This

Those who know do
not talk

And talkers do not
know.

Stop your senses,

Close the doors;

Let sharp things be
blunted,

Tangles resolved,

The light tempered

And turmoil
subdued;

For this is

If you know, you
don't talk. If you talk,
you don't know.
Don't speak of the
Tao. Don't indulge
your senses. Don't be
arrogant. Drop all
beliefs. Lose
self-importance.
Dismiss all
knowledge.

He who knows the
truth does not brag,

He who brags does
not know the truth.

Closing the
apertures, Shutting
the doors,

Blunting the
sharpness, Resolving
inner conflicts,

Softening brightness,
and

Harmonizing with
the dusty world,

He is then in
profound

One who knows does
not speak,

One who speaks does
not know.

Stop the apertures,

Close the door;

Blunt the sharp,

Untie the entangled;

Harmonize the
bright,

Make identical the
dust.

This is called

is called original
unity.

It can't be embraced
It can't be escaped, It
can't be helped It
can't be harmed, It
can't be exalted It
can't be despised,
Therefore it is
revered under
Heaven.

mystic unity

In which the Wise
Man is moved

Neither by affection

Nor yet by
estrangement

Or profit or loss

Or honor or shame.

Accordingly, by all
the world,

He is held highest.

Here you reach
non-duality. Once
enlightened, you
have no friends or
enemies. You cannot
be rewarded or
punished. You
cannot be honoured
or disgraced.
Detached from self,
you can be called a
real human.

harmony with Tao.

Thus he is no longer:

Affected by being
close to, or

Bothered by being
distant from others;

Touched by gains, or

Influenced by losses

Tempted by
nobleness, or

Shamed by
lowliness.

Therefore he is
respected by the
world.

the mystical identity
(hsüan t'ung).

Therefore with this
person you cannot
get intimate (ch'in),

Cannot get distant,

Cannot benefit,

Cannot harm,

Cannot exalt,

Cannot humiliate.

Therefore such
person is the exalted
of the world.

Use the unexpected to govern the country, Use surprise to wage war, Use non-action to win the world. How do I know? Like this!

The more prohibitions and rules, The poorer people become. The sharper people's weapons, The more they riot.

The more skilled their techniques, The more grotesque their works.

"Govern the realm by the right,
And battles by stratagem."

The world is won by refraining.

How do I know this is so?

By this:

As taboos increase, people grow poorer;

When weapons abound, the state grows chaotic;

Where skills multiply, novelties

To be a good father, you must follow the natural way. There can be no static ideas. The children are allowed to follow their own course. The more rules you have, the less they will obey. The more punishment you give, the less happy they will be.

Govern a state by fair rules.

Conduct military operations by surprise strategies.

Take over an empire as a nonevent.

How do I know these should be so?

Because:

The more prohibitions proliferate, the poorer the people;

The more sharp weapons people possess, the more chaotic the state;

The more cunning people become, the more abnormal

Govern a state by (i) the normal (cheng);

Conduct warfare as (i) the abnormal (ch'i);

Take the empire when (i) there is no business.

How do I know such should be the case?

By the following:

In an empire with many prohibitions,

People are often poor;

When people have many sharp weapons,

The state is in great darkness (tzu hun);

When persons abound in ingenuity (ch'iao),

Abnormal (ch'i) objects

The more elaborate the laws, The more they commit crimes.

Therefore the Sage says, I do nothing And people transform themselves. I enjoy serenity And people govern themselves.

I cultivate emptiness And people become prosperous. I have no desires And people simplify themselves.

flourish;

As statutes increase, more criminals start.

So the Wise Man will say:

As I refrain, the people will reform:

Since I like quiet, they will keep order;

When I forebear, the people will prosper;

When I want nothing, they will be honest.

The more you interfere, the less self-reliant they are. Therefore a master says: I do not create rules and the children act truthfully. I do not punish, and the children are happy. I do not interfere, and the children develop naturally. If a father has no desires for his children, their fulfilment is guaranteed.

the society;

The more laws promulgate, the more robbers and thieves appear.

Thus a wise ruler says:

I take no action, the people are naturally peaceful;

I love tranquility, the people naturally become orderly;

I plan no wasteful event, the people naturally grow prosperous;

I entertain no desire, the people naturally remain simple and honest.

multiply (tzu ch'i);

When laws are abundantly promulgated (tzu chang),

There are many thieves and brigands.

Therefore the sage says:

I do not act (wei),

Hence the people transform by themselves (tzu-hua);

I love tranquillity (ching),

Hence the people are normal by themselves (tzu-cheng);

I have no business,

Hence the people grow rich by themselves;

I have no desire,

Hence the people are like the uncarved wood by themselves (tzu-p'u).

Chapter 58

Addiss & Lombardo

Chapter 58

Raymond B. Blakney

Chapter 58

David Bullen

Chapter 58

David Hong Cheng

Chapter 58

Ellen Marie Chen

If government is muted and muffled
People are cool and refreshed. If government investigates and intrudes, People are worn down and hopeless.

Bad fortune rests upon good fortune.
Good luck hides within bad luck.

Who knows how it will end?

Listlessly govern:
Happy your people;
Govern exactly:
Restless your people.

"Bad fortune will
Promote the good;
Good fortune, too,
Gives rise to the bad."

But who can know to what that leads?

For it is wrong and would assign

To right

A father that is understanding and kind has children who are honest and content. A father that is strict and harsh has children who are deceitful and cunning. The higher the standard a father expects, the lower the results for the child.

When a ruler is tolerant and understanding,

The people will be loyal and obedient;

When a ruler is intolerant and overbearing,

The people will be resentful and resistant.

There are misfortunes wherein clues of blessings lie;

There are blessings wherein seeds of misfortunes hide.

Who would know the

When the government (cheng) is dull,

Its people are wholesome;

When the government is efficient (ch'a),

Its people are deficient (ch'üeh).

Calamities (huo) are what blessings depend on,

In blessings are latent calamities (huo).

Who knows where is the turning point (chi)?

Because there is no longer the normal (cheng),

If there is no principle Principle reverts to disorder, Good reverts to calamity, People's confusion hardens and lingers on.

Therefore the Sage squares without cutting, Corners without dividing, Straightens without extending, Shines without dazzling.

the strangest derivations

And would mean that goodness

Is produced by magic means!

Has man thus been so long astray?

Accordingly, the Wise Man

Is square but not sharp,

Honest but not malign,

Straight but not severe,

Bright but not dazzling.

Try to make a child happy and you will bring about his misery. Force morals on a child, and he will become immoral. Realise that every coin has two sides. All a father can do is set an example which he would be happy for his children to mimic.

final outcome?

There is no rule to go by!

Normalcy reverts to chaos;

Good reverts to evil.

People have puzzled over these for a long time!

Therefore a wise ruler is:

Square but not cutting,

Sharp but not piercing,

Straight but not stretching and

Illustrious but not dazzling.

The normal reverts and appears as the strange (ch'i),

The good reverts and appears as the uncanny.

Rulers (jen) have lost their way,

For a long stretch of days.

Therefore the sage is square but not cutting (ko),

Sharp but not injurious,

Straight but not overreaching,

Bright (kuang) but not dazzling.

Chapter 59

Addiss & Lombardo

Chapter 59

Raymond B. Blakney

Chapter 59

David Bullen

Chapter 59

David Hong Cheng

Chapter 59

Ellen Marie Chen

Governing people and serving heaven Is like living off the land.

Living sparingly and responding quickly Means accumulating Te. There is nothing that cannot be overcome. There is no limit.

"For ruling men or serving God,

There's nothing else like stores saved up."

By "stores saved up" is meant forehandedness,

Accumulate Virtue, such that nothing

Can resist it and its limit

None can guess: such infinite resource

A father who is moderate is able to be a genuine support. Because he doesn't consider himself, his acts are full of virtue.

Governing the people or interacting with Nature,

Nothing is more important than being frugal.

Only being frugal can one be prepared for the future.

Early preparation emphasizes heavy conservation of resources.

Emphasizing conservation

In governing people and serving heaven,

Nothing is better than being sparing (se).

Being sparing,

Is called early adherence [to Tao].

Adhering early,

Is called being heavy with accumulated te (chung chi te).

To be heavy with accumulated te,

Then [such a person is] all overcoming.

Being

You can become the country And the country's mother, and nourish and extend it.

This is called deep roots, firm base. This is the Tao of living long and seeing far.

Allows the jurisdiction of the king;

Whose kingdom then will long endure

If it provides the Mother an abode.

Indeed it is the deeply rooted base,

The firm foundation of the Way

To immortality of self and name.

Having no vision of the future, he is totally present. Without fixed ideas, he can fit perfectly to any situation.

The master has no self, therefore knows no limits. Even death cannot stop him.

assures no obstacles in the future.

No future obstacle, then the prospect knows no limit.

Knowing of no limit, a state is well prepared.

Govern the state with this principle,

It will long endure.

all overcoming,

Then there is no knowing the limit (chi).

Not knowing the limit,

One may rule a state.

Having the mother of a state,

It may last long.

This is called being deeply rooted and firmly founded,

The way to long life and enduring vision (chiu shih).

Chapter 60

Addiss & Lombardo

Chapter 60

Raymond B. Blakney

Chapter 60

David Bullen

Chapter 60

David Hong Cheng

Chapter 60

Ellen Marie Chen

Govern big countries
Like you cook a little
fish.

When Tao
harmonizes the
world, Demons lose
their power.

Not that demons lose
their power, but their
power does not harm
people.

Rule a large country

As small fish are
cooked.

The evil spirits of the
world

Lose sanction as
divinities

When government
proceeds

According to the
Way;

But even if they do
not lose

Their ghostly
countenance and
right,

The people

In fathering, care
must be taken not to
spoil a child. If you
give more than is
asked, this is
excessive. When you
follow the natural
way, good or bad
cannot sway you.

Governing a large
state is like cooking a
small fish.

Let Tao prevail in the
world,

Even the spiritual
beings lose their
divine appeal.

Not only they lose
their appeal,

Governing a great
state,

Is like cooking small
fish.

If you rule the world
by Tao,

The ghosts (kuei)
will lose their
spiritual (shen)
power.

Not that the ghosts
lose their spiritual
power,

But their

Not that their power
does not harm
people, but the Sage
does not harm
people.

If neither does harm,
Then Te flows and
returns.

take no harm from
them;

And if the spirits
cannot hurt the folk,

The Wise Man surely
does no hurt to them.

Since then the Wise
Man and the people

Harm each other not
at all,

Their several virtues
should converge.

You realise that
which is considered
bad, may be good,
and visa versa.
Dropping ideas of
good or bad, your
actions are natural.

Their appeal harms
no people.

Not only their appeal
harms no people,

Neither the ruler
harms people.

Since both inflict no
harm,

Then all the benefits
accrue jointly to the
people.

spiritual power will
not harm the people.

Not that their
spiritual power will
not harm the people,

But neither does the
sage harm the people.

Since both are
harmless,

Te flows back and
forth [without
impediment].

A great nation flows
down To be the
world's pool, The
female under heaven
In stillness The
female constantly
overcomes the male,
In stillness Takes the
low place.

Therefore a great
nation Lowers itself
And wins over a
small one.

The great land is a
place
To which the streams
descend;
It is the concourse and
The female of the
world:
Quiescent,
underneath,
It overcomes the male.
By quietness and by
humility
The great land then
puts down the small
And gets it for its
own;
But small lands too
absorb the great
By their subservience.
Thus some lie

A great master is
prepared for nothing,
so is ready for
anything. He trusts in
the Tao and accepts
he cannot control its
movement. Realising
its greatness, he
serves it.

A big state is like the
downstream of a
river, where the
world converges, and
which functions as
the female
of the world.

The female always
overcomes the male
through stillness.
Stillness means lying
low.

Therefore,
When a big state
places itself below a
small state,

It gains the trust of
the small state;

When a small state
places itself below a
big state,

A large state is down
stream (hsia liu).

Where the rivers
under heaven (t'ien
hsia) converge,

Is the female (p'in)
under heaven.

The female always
wins the male (mou)
by stillness (ching),

By stillness it is
low-lying (hsia).

Therefore, by being
low-lying (hsia) to a
small state,

A large state acquires
(ch'ü) a small state.

By lowering (hsia)
itself to a large state,

A small state

A small nation keeps
itself low And wins
over a great one.
Sometimes becoming
low wins, Sometimes
staying low wins.

A great nation
desires nothing more
Than to unite and
protect people. A
small nation desires
nothing more Than to
enter the service of
people.

When both get what
they wish The great
one should be low.

low, designing
conquest's ends;
While others lowly
are, by nature bent
To conquer all the
rest.
The great land's
foremost need is to
increase
The number of its
folk;
The small land needs
above all else to find
Its folk more room to
work.
That both be served
and each attain its
goal
The great land should
attempt humility.

Thus he is humble
and feminine.
Humble and
feminine, he allows
himself to be
nourished by the Tao.
Being nourished by
the Tao, he himself
becomes great.
Greatness can only
be achieved through
humility.

gains the confidence
of the big state.

Thus:

Sometimes a state
lies low in order to
gain,

Sometimes a state
lying low results in
gain.

A big state wishes
only to dominate and
lead,

A small state desires
only to join and
follow.

Now that each of the
two gets what is
wants,

It would still be
better for the big
state to lie low.

acquires a large state.

The one acquires by
being low-lying
(hsia),

The other acquires by
lowering (hsia).

A large state without
overstepping its
boundary (pu kuo),

Wishes to keep
others under its
wings.

A small state without
overstepping its
boundary (pu kuo),

Wishes to offer
service to others.

Now both are granted
their proper wishes,

Chapter 62

Addiss & Lombardo

Chapter 62

Raymond B. Blakney

Chapter 62

David Bullen

Chapter 62

David Hong Cheng

Chapter 62

Ellen Marie Chen

Tao is the mysterious center of all things, a treasure for those who are good, A refuge for those who are not.

Beautiful words can be traded, Noble deeds can enhance reputations, But if people lack them, Why should they be rejected?

When the Son of Heaven

Like the gods of the shrine in the home, So the Way and its mystery waits

In the world of material things:

The good man's treasure,

The bad man's refuge.

Fair wordage is ever for sale;

Fair manners are worn like a cloak;

But why should there be such waste

Of the badness in men?

On the day of the emperor's crowning,

When

Everything springs from the Tao. It shelters both the good and the bad. Men may try to succeed through their words and actions, but they are of benefit only if they lead to the Tao. There is little value in travelling a lifetime gathering wealth.

Tao holds secrets of all things.

It is the treasure for good people, and

The protector for bad people.

Fine talks can earn one respect,

Good deeds can elevate one's status.

Then for those who have behaved badly, why abandon them?

Thus:

When crowning a king or installing three

To all beings Tao is the hidden secret (ao):

To the good persons it is their treasure (pao),

To the not good it is that by which they are preserved (pao).

Beautiful speech can go to the market.

Respectable conduct can be bestowed on others.

Those who are not good,

Why discard them?

Therefore on crowning the Son of Heaven,

On appointing

is enthroned And the Three Ministers installed, Presenting jade discs And four-horse chariots Cannot compare to sitting still And offering the Tao.

The ancients honoured this Tao. Didn't they say: Through it seekers find, Through it the guilty escape? This is why Tao is honoured under Heaven.

the three noble dukes are appointed,

Better than chaplets of jade

Drawn by a team of four horses,

Bring the Way as your tribute.

How used the ancients to honor the Way?

Didn't they say that the seeker may find it,

And that sinners who find are forgiven?

So did they lift up the Way and its Virtue

Above everything else in the world.

Ultimately value can only be found in the Tao. Why did the ancient masters value the Tao so highly? Because with the Tao, what you need, you get. Acting in accord with the Tao you are infallible. That is why its value is beyond measure.

ministers,

In spite of their beautiful jade offerings preceded by fast horses,

It would be better to offer them Tao.

What made the ancients value Tao?

Did they not believe that:

You would get what you seek and be forgiven of your sins?

Therefore, it is valued by the world.

the Three Ducal Ministers (kung),

Although there are tributes of jade,

Preceding teams of four horses,

It is better to kneel (tso) and present this Tao.

Why did the ancients honor this Tao?

One does not say that they did it for the purpose of gain,

Rather they wish to be free from offenses (tsui).

Therefore they were the honored under heaven.

Chapter 63

Addiss & Lombardo

Chapter 63

Raymond B. Blakney

Chapter 63

David Bullen

Chapter 63

David Hong Cheng

Chapter 63

Ellen Marie Chen

Act without acting.
Serve without
serving. Taste
without tasting.

Big, little, Many,
few, Repay hatred
with Te.

Map difficult with
easy Approach great
through narrow.

The most difficult
things in the world
Must be
accomplished
through the easiest.

Act in repose;
Be at rest when you
work;

Relish unflavored
things.

Great or small,

Frequent or rare,

Requite anger with
virtue.

Take hard jobs in
hand

While they are easy;

And great affairs too

While they are small.

The troubles of the
world

Cannot be solved
except

Before they grow too
hard.

Act without
expecting results. Let
the Tao do your
work. Taste without
tasting. Look at the
big as small; think of
the many as few.
Have compassion for
petty tyrants. Deal
with things when
they arise. Complete
great works by
gradually fulfilling
them. To become a
master of the Tao,
take one step at a
time.

Take no willful
action,

Diffuse contentious
even to nonevent,

Transform the
tasteless tasteful.

Big or small,
numerous or few,

Repay enmities with
virtue.

Anticipate
difficulties while it is
still easy,

Prepare for being big
while it is still small.

Difficult problems in
the world must have
grown from what
used to be easy,

Do (wei) when there
is nothing to do
(wu-wei),

Manage affairs (shih)
when there are none
to manage,

Know (chih) by not
knowing.

Regard the great as
small, the much as
little.

Repay injury (yüan)
with te.

Plan the difficult
while it is easy.

Accomplish (wei) the
great when it is
small.

Difficult affairs of
the world,

The greatest things in
the world Must be
accomplished
through the smallest.

Therefore the Sage
Never attempts great
things and so
accomplishes them.

Quick promises
Mean little trust.
Everything easy
Means great
difficulty.

Thus for the Sage
everything is
difficult, And so in
the end Nothing is
difficult.

world

Cannot be done except

While relatively
small.

The Wise Man, then,
throughout his life

Does nothing great
and yet achieves

A greatness of his
own.

Again, a promise
lightly made

Inspires little
confidence;

Or often trivial, sure
that man

Will often come to
grief.

Choosing hardship,
then, the Wise Man

When your foothold
is firm, the next step
will come naturally.
The master never
aspires to greatness,
but is immersed in
every step. This is his
greatness. Promises
can be broken. What
is easy can become
difficult. The master
realises he must
ground his step
before he can take
another. For this
reason, he never
falls.

Great events in the
world must have
started from what
used to be small.\

So the sage does not
aim to be great,

Thus he can achieve
greatness.

Light promises often
result in loss of
credibility,

Easy encounters
often are followed by
difficulties.

So even the sage
anticipates difficulty,

Thus he encounters
no difficulty.

easy.

Great affairs of the
world,

Must be done while
they are small.

The sage never does
anything great,

Therefore he can
accomplish the great.

He who makes
promises lightly
seldom keeps his
words.

He who takes much
to be easy finds much
to be difficult.

Therefore even the
sage takes things to
be difficult,

So that in the end
they are not difficult.

Chapter 64

Addiss & Lombardo

Chapter 64

Raymond B. Blakney

Chapter 64

David Bullen

Chapter 64

David Hong Cheng

Chapter 64

Ellen Marie Chen

At rest is easy to hold. Not yet impossible is easy to plan. Brittle is easy to break. Fine is easy to scatter.

Create before it exists. Lead before it goes astray.

A tree too big to embrace Is born from a slender shoot. A nine-story rises from a pile of earth. A thousand-mile journey Begins with a single step.

Act and you ruin it. Grasp and you lose it.

A thing that is still is easy to hold.

Given no omen, it is easy to plan.

Soft things are easy to melt.

Small particles scatter easily.

The time to take care is before it is done.

Establish order before confusion sets in.

Tree trunks around which you can reach with

your arms were at first only minuscule sprouts.

A nine-storied terrace began with a clod.

A thousand-mile journey began with a foot put down.

Doing spoils it, grabbing misses it;

So the Wise Man refrains from doing

and doesn't spoil anything;

He

A tall tree requires deep roots, otherwise it will topple. If a problem is prevented, it doesn't arise. If your attainment is brittle it will easily shatter. Small things are easily lost. Don't take short cuts, but deal with everything fully before moving on. If you do this your progress will be steady. A mighty oak rises out of an acorn. A human develops out of a microscopic egg. A thousand mile journey starts with one step. These processes cannot be completed in one act.

In an orderly state, it is easy to maintain status quo;

Before the appearance of trouble, it is easy to diffuse it.

What is fragile is easy to break;

What is small is easy to scatter.

Prevent problems before they become problems;

Establish rules of order before there is disorder.

A tree of huge proportions is grown from a tiny sapling;

A nine story tower is built from the ground up;

A journey of a thousand li begins under the feet (with the first step).

He who takes willful actions fails;

What is at equilibrium is easy (i) to maintain;

What has not emerged is easy (i) to plan (mou);

What is fragile is easy (i) to dissolve;

What is minute is easy (i) to disperse.

Act (wei) when there is yet nothing to do.

Govern (chih) when there is yet no disorder (luan).

A tree whose trunk is of a man's embrace,

Begins from something extremely tiny.

A tower of nine stories high,

Is built from a heap of earth.

A trip of a thousand miles,

Begins right at one's feet.

He who acts (wei) fails,

Therefore the Sage Does not act And so does not ruin Does not grasp And so does not lose.

People commonly ruin their work When they are near success. Proceed at the end as at the beginning And your work won't be ruined.

Therefore the Sage Desires no desires Prizes no prizes Studies no studies And returns To what others pass by. The Sage Helps all beings find their nature, But does not presume to act.

grabs at nothing so never misses.

People are constantly spoiling a project

when it lacks only a step to completion.

To avoid making a mess of it,

be as careful of the end as you were of the beginning.

So the Wise Man wants the unwanted;

he sets no high value on anything

because it is hard to get.

He studies what others neglect

and restores to the world what multitudes have passed by.

His object is to restore everything to its natural course,

but he dares take no steps to that end.

He who exerts willful control loses it.

So a wise ruler:

Takes no willful action, thus suffers no failure;

Exerts no willful control, thus suffers no loss of it.

People often fail at the sight of success,

Be deft and cautious at the end as at the beginning,

Then there will be no failure.

So a wise ruler:

Desires no selfish desire,

Values no rare commodity,

Learns to unlearn, and

Repairs wrongs done to the multitude.

He thus fosters the natural state of all things, and

He dares not interfere with it.

He who holds on to loses.

Therefore the sage does not act (wei) so he does not fail,

He does not hold on to, so he does not lose.

The people in launching their projects,

Often fail when these are near completion.

Had they been as careful at the end as at the beginning,

There would have been no failures.

Therefore the sage desires not to desire,

He does not treasure hard-to-get goods;

Learns not to learn,

He recovers the transgressions (kuo) of many.

In assisting the self-becoming (tzu-jan) of all beings,

He dares not act (wei).

Chapter 65

Addiss & Lombardo

Taoist rulers of old
Did not enlighten
people But left them
dull.

People are difficult to
govern Because they
are very clever.
Therefore, Ruling
through cleverness
leads to rebellion.

Chapter 65

Raymond B. Blakney

Those ancients who
were skilled in the
Way

Did not enlighten
people by their rule

But had them ever
held in ignorance:

The more the folk
know what is going
on

The harder it
becomes to govern
them.

For public
knowledge of the
government

Is such a thief that it
will spoil the realm;

But when good
fortune brings good

Chapter 65

David Bullen

A master doesn't
teach, but shows his
disciples that what
they think they know,
they don't. If a person
thinks they know,
they are trapped in
that knowledge.

Once the master
shows them
not-knowing, they
can guide
themselves.

Chapter 65

David Hong Cheng

Ancient rulers who
were good at
practicing Tao,

Did not aim to
enlighten the people,
but to keep them
ignorant.

The difficulty in
governing the people
is due to their
excessive
knowledge.

Therefore:

He who governs a
state through
knowledge is the
robber of the state;

He who governs a
state not

Chapter 65

Ellen Marie Chen

Those in the past
who were good at
practicing Tao,

Did not want to
enlighten (ming) the
people,

But to keep them in
ignorance (yü).

People are hard to
rule,

Because they know
(chih) too much.

Therefore, to rule a
nation by knowledge,

Is to be the nation's
thief.

Not to rule

Not leading through
cleverness Brings
good fortune.

Know these two
things And
understanding the
enduring pattern.
Understand the
enduring pattern:
This is called original
Te.

Original Te goes
deep and far. All
things reverse Return
And reach the great
headwaters.

times to all

The land is ruled
without publicity.

To know the
difference between
these two

Involves a standard
to be sought and
found.

To know that
standard always,
everywhere,

Is mystic Virtue,
justly known as such;

Which Virtue is so
deep and reaching
far,

It causes a return,
things go back

At this stage the
master's task is
completed. The
master doesn't try to
show his prowess,
but lets his disciples
discover theirs.

Therefore his
disciples never resent
him and simply allow
him to point out their
true essence.

through knowledge is
the blessing of the
state.

He who knows these
two alternatives also
values the model of
Tao.

Always valuing the
model of Tao
constitutes a
profound virtue.

The virtue is so
profound and so
far-reaching,

Until the model
becomes contrary to
the reality!

Only then the great
harmony would
prevail.

a nation by
knowledge,

Is to be the nation's
blessing.

To know these two is
to know heaven's rule
(chi shih).

Always knowing
heaven's rule,

Is called the dark
(hsüan) te.

The dark te clarifies
(ch'ing) and is far
away (yüan).

It reverts (fan) with
things.

Then there arrives
the great harmony.

Chapter 66

Addiss & Lombardo

Rivers and seas Can rule the hundred valleys Because they are good at lying low They are lords of the valleys.

Therefore those who would be above Must speak as if they are below Those who would lead Must speak as if they

Chapter 66

Raymond B. Blakney

How could the rivers and the seas
Become like kings to valleys?
Because of skill in lowliness
They have become the valley's lords.
So then to be above the folk,
You speak as if you were beneath;
And if you wish to be out front,
Then act as if you were behind.
The Wise

Chapter 66

David Bullen

The ocean is the destination of all rivers. Why? Because it is placed below them. This shows the value of humility. A father, who parents his children with humility, follows them.

Chapter 66

David Hong Cheng

Why the large river or sea is able to be the king of hundred valley streams?
Because it lies well below them.
Therefore it becomes their king.
It follow that: He who governs the people must declare that he is to serve them;
He who lead the people

Chapter 66

Ellen Marie Chen

Rivers and seas can be kings of the hundred valleys,
Because they are good at flowing downwards (hsia).
Therefore they can be kings of the hundred valleys.
Thus if you desire to be above the people,
Your words must reach down (hsia) to them.
If you desire to lead the people,
Your person (shen,

are behind.
In this way the Sage dwells above And the people are not burdened. Dwells in front And they are not hindered. Therefore the whole world Is delighted and unwearied.
Since the Sage does not contend No one can contend with the Sage.

Man so is up above
But is no burden to the folk;
His station is ahead of them
To see they do not come to harm.
The world will gladly help along
The Wise Man and will bear no grudge.
Since he contends not for his own
The world will not contend with him.

By following them they will never feel oppressed and can develop naturally. His humility allows them to express themselves fully. He is beyond gratitude.

must place himself behind them.
So a wise ruler:
Stays above, the people feel no burden;
Leads ahead, the people feel no threat.
Thus the world is not tired of happily supporting him.
Since he contends against no one,
Therefore no one in the world can contend against him.

body) must be behind them.
Thus the sage is above,
Yet the people do not feel his weight.
He stays in front,
Yet the people do not suffer any harm.
Thus all gladly praise him untiringly (pu yen).
Because he does not contend with any,
Therefore no one under heaven can contend with him.

Chapter 67

Addiss & Lombardo

Everyone under heaven calls my Tao great, and unlike anything else. It is great only because It is unlike anything else. If it were like anything else It would stretch and become thin.

I have three treasures to maintain and conserve: the first is compassion. The second is frugality. The third is not presuming To be first under heaven.

Chapter 67

Raymond B. Blakney

Everywhere, they say the Way, our doctrine, Is so very like detested folly;

But greatness of its own alone explains

Why it should be thus held beyond the pale.

If it were only orthodox, long since

It would have seemed a small and petty thing!

I have to keep three treasures well secured:

The first, compassion; next, frugality;

And third, I say that never would I once

Presume that I should be

Chapter 67

David Bullen

The Tao may appear to be idealistic, but if you can put it into practice, you realise its greatness. There are three traits which are required. 1. Compassion. 2. Patience. 3. Humility

Compassionate and you can face things the way they are.

Chapter 67

David Hong Cheng

The entire world says that my Tao is great, but

It resembles not what is expected.

Just because of its greatness, it resembles to what is expected.

Otherwise, it would have become insignificant long ago.

I have three treasures, keep and treasure them:

The first is to love,

The second is to conserve, and

The third is dare not be the first in the world.

Chapter 67

Ellen Marie Chen

All under heaven say that my Tao is great, That it seems useless (pu hsiao).

Because it is great, Therefore it seems useless.

If it were useful, It would have long been small.

I have three treasures (pao), To hold and to keep:

The first is motherly love (tz'u),

The second is frugality (chien),

The third is daring not be at the world's front.

With motherly love one can be courageous,

With frugality

Compassion leads to courage. Frugality allows generosity. Not presuming to be first Creates a lasting instrument.

Nowadays, People reject compassion But want to be brave, Reject frugality But want to be generous, Reject humility And want to come first. This is death.

Compassion: Attack with it and win. Defend with it and stand firm. Heaven aids and protects Through compassion.

the whole world's chief.

Given compassion, I can take courage;

Given frugality, I can abound;

If I can be the world's most humble man,

Then I can be its highest instrument.

Bravery today knows no compassion;

Abundance is, without frugality,

And eminence without humility:

This is the death indeed of all our hope.

In battle, 'tis compassion wins the day;

Defending, 'tis compassion that is firm:

Compassion arms the people God would save!

Thus you can forgive yourself of any mistake. Patient and you remain unmoved until the right opportunity arises. Humble and you overcome self-importance, thus the ego. In following the Tao, these are your three most valuable treasures.

able to conserve, then you can be generous.

Dare not to be the first in the world, then you can be the leader.

Now:

To abandon love and be courageous,

To abandon conservation and be generous,

To abandon no be the first in the world and rush ahead.

This is fatal!

Because of love, you will be victorious in battle, and invincible in Defense!

When Heaven is about to save you, it protects you with love.

one can be wide reaching,

Daring not be at the world's front,

One can grow to a full vessel (ch'i).

Now to discard motherly love, yet to be courageous,

To discard frugality, yet to be wide reaching,

To discard staying behind, yet to be at the front,

One dies!

One with motherly love is victorious in battle,

Invulnerable in defense.

When Heaven wills to save a people,

It guards them with motherly love.

Chapter 68

Addiss & Lombardo

Chapter 68

Raymond B. Blakney

Chapter 68

David Bullen

Chapter 68

David Hong Cheng

Chapter 68

Ellen Marie Chen

The accomplished person is not aggressive. The good soldier is not hot tempered.

The best conqueror does not engage the enemy.

A skillful soldier is not violent;

An able fighter does not rage;

A mighty conqueror does not give battle;

A great commander is a humble man.

You may

The best warrior isn't intent on killing. The best sportsman isn't concerned about winning. The best tactician enters the mind of his opponent.

A good statesman does not rely on his military strength;

A good fighter does not lose his temper;

A good winner does not argue with his adversary;

A good employer

A good captain does not exhibit his martial prowess.

A good warrior does not get himself angry.

A good conqueror of enemies does not instigate a combat.

A good employer of

The most effective leader takes the lowest place.

This is called the Te of not contending. This is called the power of the leader. This is called matching Heaven's ancient ideal.

call this pacific virtue;

Or say that it is mastery of men;

Or that it is rising to the measure of God,

Or to the stature of the ancients.

A true businessman works for the good of the community, not to rape them of their wealth and destroy the earth. A true leader has no agenda. Competition breeds violence. Peace can only be had by doing away with it.

of talents places himself below them.

This is the virtue of no contention;

This is the strength of managing talents;

This is the adaptation to Heaven,

The ultimate standard of old.

people puts himself below them.

This is called the power (te) of non-contention.

This is called using the strength of others.

This is called perfection (chi) in matching the heaven of old.

Chapter 69

Addiss & Lombardo

Chapter 69

Raymond B. Blakney

Chapter 69

David Bullen

Chapter 69

David Hong Cheng

Chapter 69

Ellen Marie Chen

There is a saying in the army: I do not presume to be the master, But become the guest. I do not dare advance an inch, but retreat a foot.

This is called moving without moving, rolling up sleeves without

The strategists have a saying:

"If I cannot be host,

Then let me be guest.

But if I dare not advance

Even an inch,

Then let me retire a foot."

This is what they call

A campaign without

There is a saying:"It is sometimes better to wait and see than to act first. It is safer to retreat a foot, than to advance and inch."

Following this saying, energy is conserved. When the correct course of action becomes apparent, you are able to act. In trying to overcome the ego, it can't be defeated directly.

The military strategist says:

I dare not be an aggressor, but a defender;

I dare not advance an inch, but to retreat a foot.

This implies that we:

March without formation;

Raise no arms;

Face

In engaging in warfare it is said:

I dare not be the host but be the guest,

I dare not advance an inch but retreat a foot.

This is called to march without advancing,

To roll up one's sleeves without baring one's arms,

To

showing your arms, Repelling without opposing, Wielding without a weapon.

There is no disaster greater than Contempt for the enemy.

Contempt for the enemy - what a treasure is lost! Therefore, When the fighting gets hot, Those who grieve will conquer.

a march,

Sleeves up but no bare arms,

Shooting but no enemies,

Or arming without weapons.

Than helpless enemies, nothing is worse:

To them I lose my treasures.

When opposing enemies meet,

The compassionate man is the winner!

Don't see it as bad, and there will be no conflict in you. If you create conflict, your three treasures will be lost, and you will become an enemy to yourself. To overcome the ego, yield to it, and simply be aware of its motivations. Once its motivations are apparent, it is discredited and will lose all power over you.

enemies undetected; and

Hold hidden weapons.

There is no greater danger than underestimating the enemy,

Underestimating the enemy nearly destroys my treasures.

Therefore:

When to armies of equal strength go to battle,

The aggrieved side wins.

throw a rope without an enemy,

To carry without a weapon.

Of all calamities (huo),

None is greater than underestimating one's enemy.

In underestimating my enemy,

I risk losing my treasure (pao).

Therefore when opposing armies are engaged in battle,

The sorrowful party will win.

Chapter 70

Addiss & Lombardo

My words are very easy to understand,
Very easy to practice.
No one under heaven can understand them,
No one can practice them.

Words have ancestors, Deeds have masters.

Chapter 70

Raymond B. Blakney

My words are easy just to understand:
To live by them is very easy too;

Yet it appears that none in all the world

Can understand or make them come to life.

My words have ancestors, my

Chapter 70

David Bullen

The way of the master is simple, and easy to practice. But your mind cannot understand, and you can't try to attain it. Ordinary people are interested in the mundane world, and even if they hear of the Tao they don't grasp its depth.

Chapter 70

David Hong Cheng

My teachings are very easy to understand and very easy to practice.
But the world cannot understand them, nor practice them.

There are:

Principles in my teachings, and

Philosophy governing my undertakings.

Simply

Chapter 70

Ellen Marie Chen

My words (yen) are very easy to understand (i-chih),
Very easy to put into practice (i-hsing).

But no one under heaven can understand (chih) them,

No one can put them into practice.

Words (yen) have their ruler (chün);

Events (shih) have their

If people don't understand this, They don't understand me.
Few understand me,
And that is my value.

Therefore the Sage wears rough clothing
And carries Jade inside.

works a prince;

Since none know this, unknown I too remain.

But honor comes to me when least I'm known:

The Wise Man, with a jewel in his breast,

Goes clad in garments made of shoddy stuff.

Few and far between are those who follow the way. They realise those who don't follow, aren't ready, so don't try to persuade them. Those who become ready have to lose all hope. Once all hope is lost, there is hope.

because of ignorance, people do not understand me.

Those who do are few, those who practice my teachings are rare.

Thus the sage is clothed in rags but hides a precious jade inside.

progenitor (tsung).

Because people do not understand (chih) this,

Therefore they do not understand me.

Those who understand me are rare,

Those who follow (tsê) my teaching are (preciously) few (kuei).

Therefore the sage wears hair-cloth,

While carrying jade in his breast.

Chapter 71

Addiss & Lombardo

Chapter 71

Raymond B. Blakney

Chapter 71

David Bullen

Chapter 71

David Hong Cheng

Chapter 71

Ellen Marie Chen

Know not-knowing:
supreme. Not know
knowing: faulty

Only faulting faults
is faultless.

To know that you are
ignorant is best;

To know what you
do not, is a disease;

But if you recognize
the malady

Of mind for what it

You can only know
when there is no
knowing. Thinking
you know is a
delusion.

Knowing what you
do not know is the
best,

Pretending to know
what you do not
know is a disease.

Only be treating the
disease as a

From knowing to not
knowing (chih, pu
chih),

This is superior.

From not knowing to
knowing (pu chih,
chih),

This is sickness.

It is by

The Sage is faultless

By faulting faults,
And so is without
fault.

is, then that is health.

The Wise Man has
indeed a healthy
mind;

He sees an aberration
as it is

And for that reason
never will be ill.

If you realise the
delusion is your own,
it can be cleared. The
master has rejected
all knowing, and his
delusion has cleared.
He is now
enlightened.

disease,

Can one be free from
it.

The sage is free from
the disease

Because he treats the
disease as a disease,
Therefore he is free
from it.

being sick of
sickness,

That one is not sick.

The sage is not sick.

Because he is sick of
sickness,

Therefore he is not
sick.

Chapter 72

Addiss & Lombardo

Chapter 72

Raymond B. Blakney

Chapter 72

David Bullen

Chapter 72

David Hong Cheng

Chapter 72

Ellen Marie Chen

When people are not
in awe of power,
Power becomes
great.

Do not intrude into
their homes, Do not
make their lives
weary.

If people do not
dread your majesty,
A greater dread will
yet descend on them.

See then you do not
cramp their dwelling
place,

Or immolate their
children or their
stock,

Nor anger them by

The master's sense of
wonder is constant,
like a déjà vu that
never ends. He
realises this wonder
is missing from
others, but leaves
them be unless they
ask for help.

When the people are
no longer afraid of
the power of
authority,

Then the awesome
power of authority
descends with a
vengeance.

Do not disturb the
people in their
habitats,

Do not choke off
their means of
livelihood.

Only

When the people fear
no power,

Then great power has
indeed arrived.

Do not disturb them
in their dwellings,

Do not weary them in
their living.

It is because you do
not weary (pu yen)
them,

That they

If you do not weary
them, They will not
becoem weary of
you.

Therefore the Sage
Has self-knowledge
without self-display,
Self-love without
personal pride,
Rejects one, accepts
the other.

your own angry
ways.

It is the Wise Man's
way to know himself,

And never to reveal
his inward thoughts;

He loves himself but
so, is not set up;

He chooses this in
preference to that.

Having no self, he
understands them. If
he would push or
prod, they would
distance themselves.
He has let go of the
idea that people can
be helped.

by not being
oppressive, will
people feel not
oppressed.

Therefore a wise
ruler:

Knows his authority,
but does not show of
his power,

Values self-respect,
but does not exalt his
position.

Thus he chooses this
and rejects the other.

are not wearied of
you.

Therefore the sage
knows himself (tzu
chih),

But does not see
himself (tzu chien).

He loves himself (tzu
ai),

But does not exalt
himself (tzu kuei).

Therefore he leaves
that and takes this.

Chapter 73

Addiss & Lombardo

Chapter 73

Raymond B. Blakney

Chapter 73

David Bullen

Chapter 73

David Hong Cheng

Chapter 73

Ellen Marie Chen

Courage to dare kills,
 Courage not to dare
 saves. One brings
 profit, one brings
 harm.

Of these two, one is
 good, and one is
 harmful. Some are
 not favored by
 heaven. Who knows
 why? Even the wise
 consider it a difficult
 question.

Heaven hates what it
 hates - Who knows
 why!

A brave man who
 dares to, will kill;

A brave man who
 dares not, spares life;

And from them both
 come good and ill;

"God hates some
 folks, but who knows
 why?"

The Wise Man
 hesitates there too:

God's Way is bound
 to

Acting passionately
 can lead to trouble.
 Being indifferent,
 there is no trouble.
 The reasons why
 things happen can
 hardly be known, so
 we can't know if
 something is good or
 bad.

To be brave in daring
 results in a killing;

To be brave in not
 daring results in life.

Of the two, one is
 beneficial, the other
 harmful.

Whatever Heaven
 disfavours,

Who knows the
 reason?

(Thus even the sage

One who is
 courageous out of
 daring (kan) is killed.

One who is
 courageous out of not
 daring lives.

Of these two, this is
 beneficial while that
 is harmful.

What heaven hates,
 who knows the
 reason?

Therefore even the
 sage takes it to be
 difficult.

The way

Even the Sage finds
 it difficult. Heaven's
 Tao does not contend
 But prevails, Does
 not speak, But
 responds, Is not
 summoned, But
 arrives, Is utterly
 still, But plans all
 actions.

Heaven's net is wide,
 wide, Loose - But
 nothing slips
 through.

conquer all

But not by strife does
 it proceed.

Not by words does
 God get answers:

He calls them not and
 all things come.

Master plans unfold
 but slowly,

Like God's wide net
 enclosing all:

Its mesh is coarse but
 none are lost.

By not trying to
 succeed, everything
 is successful.
 Without speaking,
 everything is said. By
 not seeking, it can be
 found. The natural
 way covers
 everything and every
 event like a net.
 Though its meshes
 may be wide, nothing
 slips through.

considers this a
 difficult question.)

The way of heaven is
 good at:

Winning without
 striving;

Responding without
 announcing;

Forthcoming without
 prompting; and

Planing without
 haste.

The net of Heaven is
 extremely vast,

It is coarse but not
 leaking.

of heaven:

Without contending
 (cheng), it is yet
 good at winning,

Without speaking, it
 is yet good in
 responding,

Without being
 beckoned, it yet
 comes of its own
 accord,

Unhurried, it is yet
 good at planning
 (mou).

The net of heaven is
 vast,

Widely spaced, yet
 missing nothing.

Chapter 74

Addiss & Lombardo

Chapter 74

Raymond B. Blakney

Chapter 74

David Bullen

Chapter 74

David Hong Cheng

Chapter 74

Ellen Marie Chen

If people do not fear death, How dare you threaten them with death?

But if people with a normal fear of death Are about to do something vicious, And I could seize and

The people do not fear at all to die;

What's gained therefore by threatening them with death?

If you could always make them fear de cease,

As if it were a strange event and rare,

Who then would dare

Death is a natural part of life, and it is your fate. If you accept this fully, there is no fear. Having no fear, your actions are powerful.

When the people are not afraid to die

Why then threaten them with death?

Even if they normally are fearful of death,

For worst offenders, we may seize and kill them.

But who dares to execute?

The people do not fear death,

Why threaten them with death?

Suppose the people always fear death,

One who does strange things (ch'i),

I shall seize and kill,

Then who dares [to do strange things]?

Killing is

execute them, Who would dare?

There is always an official executioner. Trying to take the executioner's place, Is like trying to replace a master woodworker - Few would not slice their own hands.

to take and slaughter them?

The executioner is always set

To slay, but those who substitute for him

Are like would-be master carpenters

Who try to chop as that skilled craftsman does

And nearly always mangle their own hands!

If you try to manage your life, you won't live. Because of death there is no risk, hence nothing to manage. A life based on death will be fulfilling. A life based on life will lead to death.

There is always an expert executioner who kills.

Substituting for an expert executioner,

Is like hacking wood in place of a master carpenter.

Whoever substitutes for the master carpenter,

He seldom escapes injury of his own hand.

carried out by the executioner.

To replace the executioner and kill,

Is like chopping wood in place of the master carpenter.

To chop wood in place of the master carpenter,

Rarely one does not hurt one's own hand.

Chapter 75

Addiss & Lombardo

Chapter 75

Raymond B. Blakney

Chapter 75

David Bullen

Chapter 75

David Hong Cheng

Chapter 75

Ellen Marie Chen

People are hungry.
When rulers tax grain
People are hungry.

People are rebellious.
When rulers are
active People are
rebellious.

People ignore death.

The people starve
because of those
Above them, who
consume by tax
In grain and kind
more than their right.

For this, the people
are in want.

The people are so
hard to rule

Because of those
who are above them,

Whose interference
makes distress.

For

If you require many
concessions from
children, they won't
be able to fulfil their
own hearts. Give
them many rules to
follow and they will
rebel.

The people are
hungry, because

Their ruler consumes
too much of their tax
grains.

That is why they are
hungry.

The people become
difficult to govern,
because

Their ruler takes
willful actions,

That is why they are

People are hungry.
Because their rulers
levy too much grain
tax,

Therefore they are
hungry.

People are hard to
rule.

Because their rulers
rule by action (wei),

Therefore they are
hard to

When searching only
for life's bounty
People ignore death.
Only those who do
not strive after life
Truly respect life.

this, they are so hard
to rule.

The people do not
fear to die;

They too demand to
live secure:

For this, they do not
fear to die.

So they, without the
means to live,

In virtue rise above
those men

Who value life above
its worth.

When people
outwardly value life,
death is taken lightly.
If death is taken
lightly, life will
easily be sacrificed.

difficult to govern.

The people take
death lightly, because

Their ruler demands
too much for his
luxurious life.

That is why they take
death lightly.

Only he who does
not overvalue his
own life excels in
valuing life.

rule.

People take death
lightly.

Because they are in
thick pursuit of life,

Therefore they take
death lightly.

One who has nothing
to pursue in life,

Is wiser than one
who values life.

Humans are born soft
and weak. They die
stiff and strong.

The ten thousand
plants and trees Are
born soft tender, And
die withered and
sere.

The stiff and strong
Are Death's

Alive, a man is
supple, soft;
In death, unbending,
rigorous.

All creatures, grass
and trees, alive
Are plastic but are
pliat too,
And dead, are friable
and dry.

Unbending rigor is
the mate of death,

When a baby is born,
it is soft and flexible.
When a man dies he
is static and stiff. A
living plant bends
and flowers. Dead, it
is brittle and barren.

A human body is
weak and pliable at
birth, and is stiff and
hard at death.

Grass and trees are
tender and soft at
birth, and are dry and
brittle at death.

Therefore,
The hard and strong
belong to the
company of death;
The soft

At birth a person is
soft (jou) and
yielding (jo),
At death hard (chien)
and unyielding
(ch'iang).

All beings, grass and
trees, when alive, are
soft and bending,
When dead they are
dry and brittle.
Therefore the hard
and unyielding

companions The soft
and weak Are Life's
companions.

Therefore the
strongest armies do
not conquer, The
greatest trees are cut
down.

The strong and great
sink down. The soft
and weak rise up.

And wielding
softness, company of
life:
Unbending soldiers
get no victories;
The stiffest tree is
readiest for the ax.
The strong and
mighty topple from
their place;
The soft and yielding
rise above them all.

Stiff and static, you
are as if dead.
Flexible and soft, you
are a beacon of life.
That which is stiff
and brittle will easily
snap, and be
destroyed. That
which is soft and
flexible will bend,
and endure.

and weak belong to
the company of life.

It follows then:
A strong army is
destined to be
destroyed;
A hard wood tree is
doomed to be broken.

The hard and strong
are in an inferior
position,
The soft and weak
are in a superior
position.

are companions of
death,
The soft and yielding
are companions of
life.
Hence an unyielding
army (ping) is
destroyed (mieh).
An unyielding tree
breaks (che).
The unyielding and
great takes its place
below,
The soft and yielding
takes its place above.

Chapter 77

Addiss & Lombardo

Chapter 77

Raymond B. Blakney

Chapter 77

David Bullen

Chapter 77

David Hong Cheng

Chapter 77

Ellen Marie Chen

Heaven's Tao Is a stretched bow,
Pulling down on the top Pulling up on the bottom.

If it's too much, cut.
If it's not enough,
Add on to it:
Heaven's Tao.

The Human Route Is not like this,
Depriving the poor,
Offering to the rich.

Is not God's Way much like a bow well bent?

The upper part has been disturbed,
pressed down;

The lower part is raised up from its place;

The slack is taken up;
the slender width

Is broader drawn; for thus the Way of God

Cuts people down when they have had too much,

And fills the bowls of those who are in want.

But not the way

The Tao functions like a bending bow. When something is gained, something else is lost. If there is excess here, there will be deficiency there. A rich man, who takes more from those who are lacking, will become deficient in the Tao.

Is Heaven's way like aiming an extended bow?

If aiming too high,
lower it;

If aiming too high,
raise it.

Thus,

The surplus is reduced and the needy supplemented.

The way of Heaven is to reduce the surplus so as to supplement the needy.

The way of Mankind is

The way of heaven,

Is it not like stretching a bow?

What is high up is pressed down,

What is low down is lifted up;

What has surplus (yu yü) is reduced,

What is deficient (pu tsu) is supplemented.

The way of heaven,

It reduces those who have surpluses,

To supplement those who are deficient.

The

Who has a surplus
And still offers it to the world? Only those with Tao.

Therefore the Sage Acts and expects nothing,
Accomplishes and does not linger, Has no desire to seem worthy.

this:

The people who have not enough are spoiled

For tribute to the rich and surfeited.

Who can benefit the world

From stored abundance of his own?

He alone who has the Way,

The Wise Man who can act apart

And not depend on others' whims;

But not because of his high rank

Will he succeed; he does not wish

The master gives, therefore he has. He doesn't need recognition and acts with no thought of reward. With no thought of reward, everything he does is rewarding.

just the opposite:

It takes away from the needy so as to enrich the surplus.

Who would offer their surpluses to the world?

Only followers of Tao.

So the sage it to:

Care for but not to master;

Complete the work without claiming credit; and

Avoid recognition of his achievements.

human way is just not so.

It reduces those who are deficient,

To offer those who have surpluses.

Who can offer his surpluses to the world?

Only a person of Tao.

Therefore the sage works (wei) without holding on to,

Accomplishes without claiming credit.

Is it not because he does not want to show off his merits?

Chapter 78

Addiss & Lombardo

Nothing in the world is soft and weak as water. But when attacking the hard and strong Nothing can conquer so easily.

Weak overcomes strong, soft overcomes hard.

Chapter 78

Raymond B. Blakney

Nothing is weaker than water,
But when it attacks something hard
Or resistant, then nothing withstands it,
And nothing will alter its way.
Everyone knows this, that weakness prevails
Over strength and that gentleness conquers
The adamant hindrance of men, but that
Nobody demonstrates

Chapter 78

David Bullen

Water is the softest thing in the world.
But in dissolving things that are hard, nothing can better it.
This is because it can't be broken, thus it endures.

Chapter 78

David Hong Cheng

Nothing in the world is softer and weaker than water.
Yet there is nothing better for conquering the hard and strong, and there is no substitute for it.
That the weak overcomes the strong and
The soft overcomes the hard,
Is understood by the

Chapter 78

Ellen Marie Chen

Nothing under heaven
Is softer (jou) and weaker (jo) than water,
Yet nothing can compare with it
In attacking the hard (chien) and strong (ch'iang).
Nothing can change (i) place with it.
That the weak overcomes the strong,
And the soft overcomes the hard,
No one under heaven does not know (chih),

Everyone knows this, no one attains it.
Therefore the Sage says: Accept a country's filth And become master of its sacred soil. Accepts country's ill fortune And become king under heaven. True words resemble their opposites.

how it is so.
Because of this the Wise Man says
That only one who bears the nations shame
Is fit to be its hallowed lord;
That only one who takes upon himself
The evils of the world may be its king.
This is paradox.

Everybody knows the soft is stronger than the hard, and the passive overcomes the aggressive, but few put this into practice. The master is humble, therefore he is great. Because he can follow, he is able to lead. Truth is paradoxical.

entire world,
But non can practice it.
So the sage says:
One who suffers disgrace for the state is qualified to be its leader.
One who carries the burden of the state's misfortune is fit to be its king.
The words of truth sound contrarian.

Though none can put it into practice.
Therefore a sage said:
"One who receives the filth of a state, Is called the Master of the Altar of the Soil and Grain;
One who shoulders the evils of a state, Becomes the king under heaven."
Straightforward words (yen) appear to be their reverse.

Chapter 79

Addiss & Lombardo

Chapter 79

Raymond B. Blakney

Chapter 79

David Bullen

Chapter 79

David Hong Cheng

Chapter 79

Ellen Marie Chen

Appears great hatred
and hatred will
remain. How can this
be good?

Therefore the Sage
Holds the tally But
does not judge
people.

How can you think it
is good

To settle a grievance
too great

To ignore, when the
settlement

Surely evokes other
piques?

The Wise Man
therefore will select

The left-hand part of
contract

Behind every failure,
is a success. If you
blame, you will be
blamed. The master
takes responsibility
for himself and is not
concerned with the
actions of others.

Deep grievances can
be ameliorated, but
residual ones remain.

How can this
situation be
improved?

Thus:

The sage holds the
left half of the debt
instrument, and never
abuses the debtor.

In reconciling a great
injury (yüan),

There is sure to have
some injury left.

How can this be
good?

Therefore the sage
holds the left tally,

He does not blame
others.

One who has

Those who have Te
Control the tally.
Those who lack Te
Collect their due.

Heaven has no
favourites But
endures in good
people.

tallies:

He will not put the
debt on other men.

This virtuous man
promotes agreement;

The vicious man
allots the blame.

"Impartial though the
Way of God may be,

It always favors good
men."

He expects nothing
from them, and
doesn't rely on them.
If a mistake is made
he accepts it.
Through this he
avoids disturbance.

A person of virtue
just keeps the left
portion; but

A person of no virtue
abuses the debtor.

The way of Heaven
is neutral,

But it always sides
with the virtuous
person.

te is in charge of the
tally,

One who has no te is
in charge of the tax
law.

The Tao of heaven
has no partiality
(ch'in),

It is always with the
good people.

Chapter 80

Addiss & Lombardo

Chapter 80

Raymond B. Blakney

Chapter 80

David Bullen

Chapter 80

David Hong Cheng

Chapter 80

Ellen Marie Chen

Small country, few people - Hundreds of devices, But none are used. People ponder on death And don't travel far.

They have carriages and boats, But no one goes on board; Weapons and armour, But no one brandishes them.

They use knotted cords for counting.

The ideal land is small
Its people very few,
Where tools abound
Ten times or yet
A hundred-fold
Beyond their use;
Where people die
And die again
But never emigrate;
Have boats and carts
Which no one rides.
Weapons have they
And armor too,
But none displayed.
The folk returns
To

When happy: Even if you have occult powers, they will not be used, You can achieve great works, but there is no need, You can travel far and wide, but you stay at home, You can become a great man, but you remain unknown, You can control people, but you leave them be.

There exists a small state with a few people.
Wherein:
Plenty of useful tools are not being used.
Valuing life, the people do not migrate faraway.
Though there are boats and carriages, no one rides in them.
Let the people return to the time of tying knots on ropes for reckoning.
Let them:

A small state with few people.
Let the implements (ch'ih) for ten and hundred men be unused,
Let the people fear death such that they do not move far away.
Although there are boats and carriages,
There are no places to ride them to.
Although there are weapons and armours,
There are no occasions to display them.
Let the

Sweet is their food, Beautiful their clothes, Peaceful their homes, Delightful their customs.

Neighboring countries are so close You can hear their chickens and dogs. But people grow old and die Without needing to come and go.

use again
The knotted chords.
Their meat is sweet;
Their clothes adorned,
Their homes at peace,
Their customs charm.
And neighbor lands
Are juxtaposed
So each may hear
The barking dogs,
The crowing cocks
Across the way;
Where folks grow old
And folks will die
And never once

Joy is found in ordinary goings on. Even though you may be able to see the border to the next country, you are content to die of old age never having been there.

Enjoy their food, Beautify their clothing,
Live in peace at home, and
Be happy with their heritage.
The people in neighbouring states are within sight of each other,
The crowing of cocks and barking of dogs are heard from each other,
Yet the people die of old age without visiting with each other.

people again tie ropes and use them (as memory aids).
Let them enjoy their food,
Consider their clothing beautiful,
Be contented with their dwellings,
And happy with their customs.
The neighbouring states overlooking one another,
The dogs' barkings and cocks' crowings are heard from other states,
Yet till they are old and dying the people do not visit one another.

Chapter 81

Addiss & Lombardo

Chapter 81

Raymond B. Blakney

Chapter 81

David Bullen

Chapter 81

David Hong Cheng

Chapter 81

Ellen Marie Chen

Sincere words and not pretty. Pretty words are not sincere.

Good people do not quarrel. Quarrelsome people are not good.

The wise are not learned. The learned are not wise.

The Sage

As honest words may not sound fine,

Fine words may not be honest ones;

A good man does not argue, and

An arguer may not be good!

The knowers are not learned men

And learned men may never know.

The Wise Man does not hoard his

True words aren't beautiful. Beautiful words are not truthful. The wise do not argue. Those who argue are not wise. Those who know have no knowledge. Those with knowledge don't know. The master has nothing, but gives everything he has. The more he gives, the happier he is.

Credible words are not artful:

Artful words are not credible.

An objective person does not argue;

A person who argues is not objective.

He who knows the truth may not be erudite;

He who is erudite may not know the truth.

The sage does

Truthful (hsin) words (yen) are not beautiful,

Beautiful (mei) words are not truthful.

The good (shan) does not distinguish,

One who distinguishes (pien) is not good.

One who knows (chih) does not accumulate knowledge,

One who accumulates knowledge (po) does not know.

The sage does not

is not acquisitive - Has enough By doing for others, Has even more By giving to others.

Heaven's Tao Benefits and does not harm. The Sage's Tao Acts and does not contend.

things;

Hard-pressed, from serving other men,

He has enough and some to spare;

But having given all he had,

He then is very rich indeed.

God's Way is gain that works no harm;

The Wise Man's way, to do his work

Without contending for a crown.

Only with the Tao can you be fulfilled. The beginning doesn't exist; the end doesn't exist, except through the other. Is finishing verse eighty-one, the end, or the beginning? If you think it is the end, you need to read it again. If you think it is the beginning, you also need to read it again.

not hoard for himself,

The more he benefits others the happier he becomes,

The more he gives away to others the wealthier he feels.

The way of Heaven; benefits all, harms none.

The way of the sage: be helpful to all, contentious against none.

hoard.

Having worked (wei) for his fellow beings,

The more he possesses.

Having donated himself to his fellow beings,

The more abundant he becomes.

The way of heaven,

It benefits (li), but does not harm.

The way of the sage,

He works (wei), but does not contend.